
... AND THE WALLS OF THE MIGHTY CITY COLLAPSE TO THE GROUND.
IN ALL OF JERICHO, ONLY RAHAB, THE WOMAN WHO BELIEVED IN GOD AND HELPED THE SCOUTS, IS SAVED.
THE ISRAELITE SOLDIERS SEARCH THE CITY FOR IRON, BRASS, SILVER, AND GOLD FOR THE TENT OF MEETING TREASURY.
LOOK AT THIS BEAUTIFUL ROBE.
WHY SHOULD I FIGHT AND NOT TAKE SOMETHING? I'LL HIDE SOMETHING, AND NO ONE WILL KNOW ...
FORGET IT. JOSHUA SAID WE CAN'T KEEP ANYTHING FOR OURSELVES.
AFTER THE VICTORY OF JERICHO, JOSHUA CALLS SOME OF THE SCOUTS TO HIM.
HERE IS THE CITY OF AI. IT GUARDS THE APPROACH OF OUR FUTURE CAMPAIGNS.
WE MUST FIND OUT HOW STRONG THE CITY IS BEFORE WE ATTACK.
WE'LL SCOUT IT OUT THE WAY WE DID JERICHO.


The Ambush of Ai
BASED ON JOSHUA 7–8
THE SCOUTS SOON RETURN TO CAMP, EAGER TO REPORT TO JOSHUA.
THE ARMY OF AI IS SMALL. WE CAN TAKE THE CITY AND LEAVE MOST OF OUR TROOPS HERE TO REST.
JOSHUA SENDS ONLY 3,000 MEN TO TAKE AI. BUT AT THE CITY GATES, THE ARMY OF AI RUNS THEM OFF.
THESE ARE THE BRAVE SOLDIERS WHO TOOK JERICHO?
LOOK AT THEM RUN! THEY'RE AFRAID TO FIGHT!
THE FRIGHTENED ISRAELITES RETURN FROM THEIR DEFEAT AT AI. JOSHUA AND THE WHOLE CAMP ARE STUNNED.
WHAT HAPPENED?
I DON'T KNOW! ALL OF A SUDDEN WE WERE AFRAID AND RAN.
THE SOLDIERS CAN'T EXPLAIN WHY THEY WERE AFRAID, SO JOSHUA SEEKS HELP FROM GOD.
GOD, WHY DID THIS HAPPEN? NOW OUR ENEMIES WILL DESTROY US.
GOD TELLS JOSHUA THAT THE PEOPLE ARE BEING PUNISHED BECAUSE SOMEONE DISOBEYED HIM WHEN THEY TOOK JERICHO.


EARLY THE NEXT MORNING, JOSHUA CALLS THE LEADERS OF THE TRIBES TO HIM.
SOMEONE DISOBEYED GOD'S ORDER AND KEPT PART OF THE SPOILS OF JERICHO. THIS MAN MUST BE PUNISHED OR WE WILL DIE AT THE HANDS OF THE ENEMY.
GOD POINTS OUT ACHAN AS THE GUILTY ONE.
IT'S TRUE. I SINNED AGAINST GOD AND MY PEOPLE.
NOW WE STAND RIGHT WITH GOD AGAIN.
NOW WITH GOD'S SUPPORT, JOSHUA LEADS SOLDIERS AGAINST AI. JOSHUA RAISES HIS SPEAR TO GIVE THE SIGNAL FOR THE ISRAELITES TO RUSH IN AND SET FIRE TO THE CITY. THE SOLDIERS OF AI ARE CAUGHT IN A TRAP AND QUICKLY DEFEATED.

Stop the Sun BASED ON JOSHUA 9—10







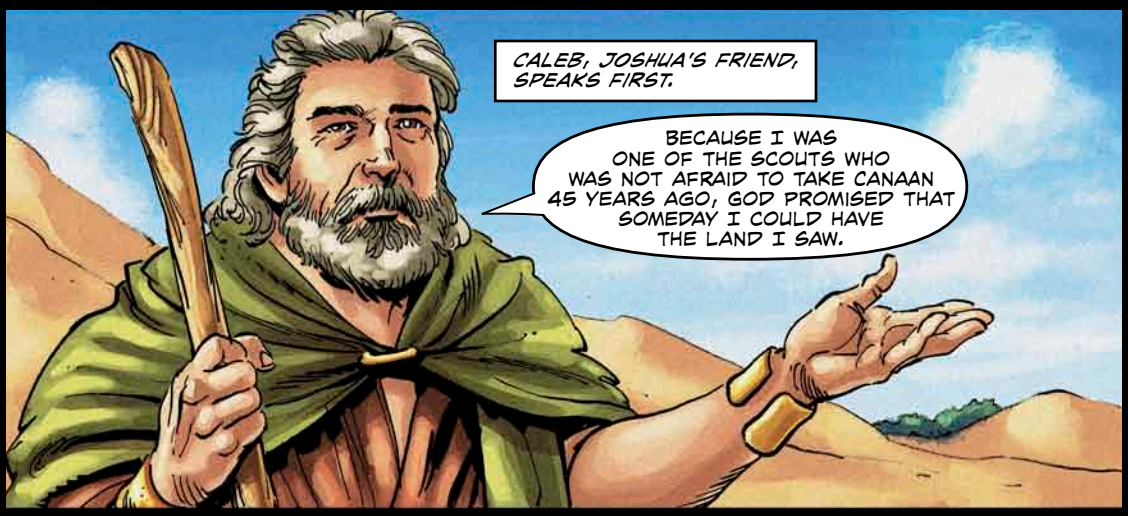



JOSHUA HONORS THE TREATY AND MARCHES HIS SOLDIERS ALL NIGHT TO CATCH THE ENEMIES OF GIBEON BY SURPRISE.
DON'T LET A SINGLE MAN ESCAPE!
FLEEING FROM THE ISRAELITES, THE ENEMY IS CAUGHT IN A TERRIBLE HAILSTORM.
WE HAVE ROUTED THE AMORITES, JOSHUA. BUT THE SUN IS ABOUT TO SET! UNDER THE COVER OF NIGHT, THEY'LL BE ABLE TO GET AWAY FROM US.
NOT IF I HAVE ANYTHING TO SAY ABOUT IT, THEY WON'T.
O LORD, MAKE THE SUN STAND STILL IN THE SKY. FREEZE THE MOON IN HER PLACE, THAT WE MAY HAVE TIME TO FINISH THIS BATTLE IN DAYLIGHT!
GOD ANSWERS JOSHUA'S PRAYER. DAYLIGHT LASTS LONG ENOUGH FOR JOSHUA TO WIN THE VICTORY AND SAVE THE PEOPLE OF GIBEON.

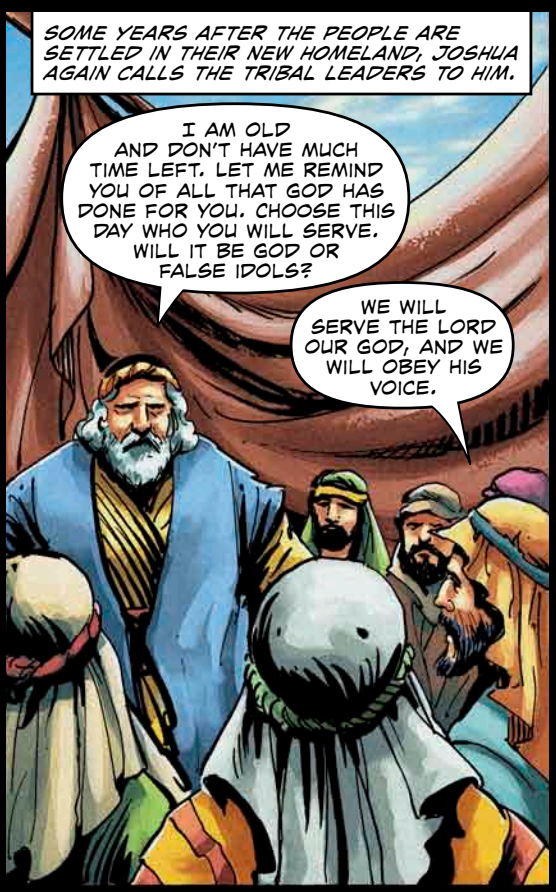
A Division Problem

BASED ON JOSHUA 11:1—24:18

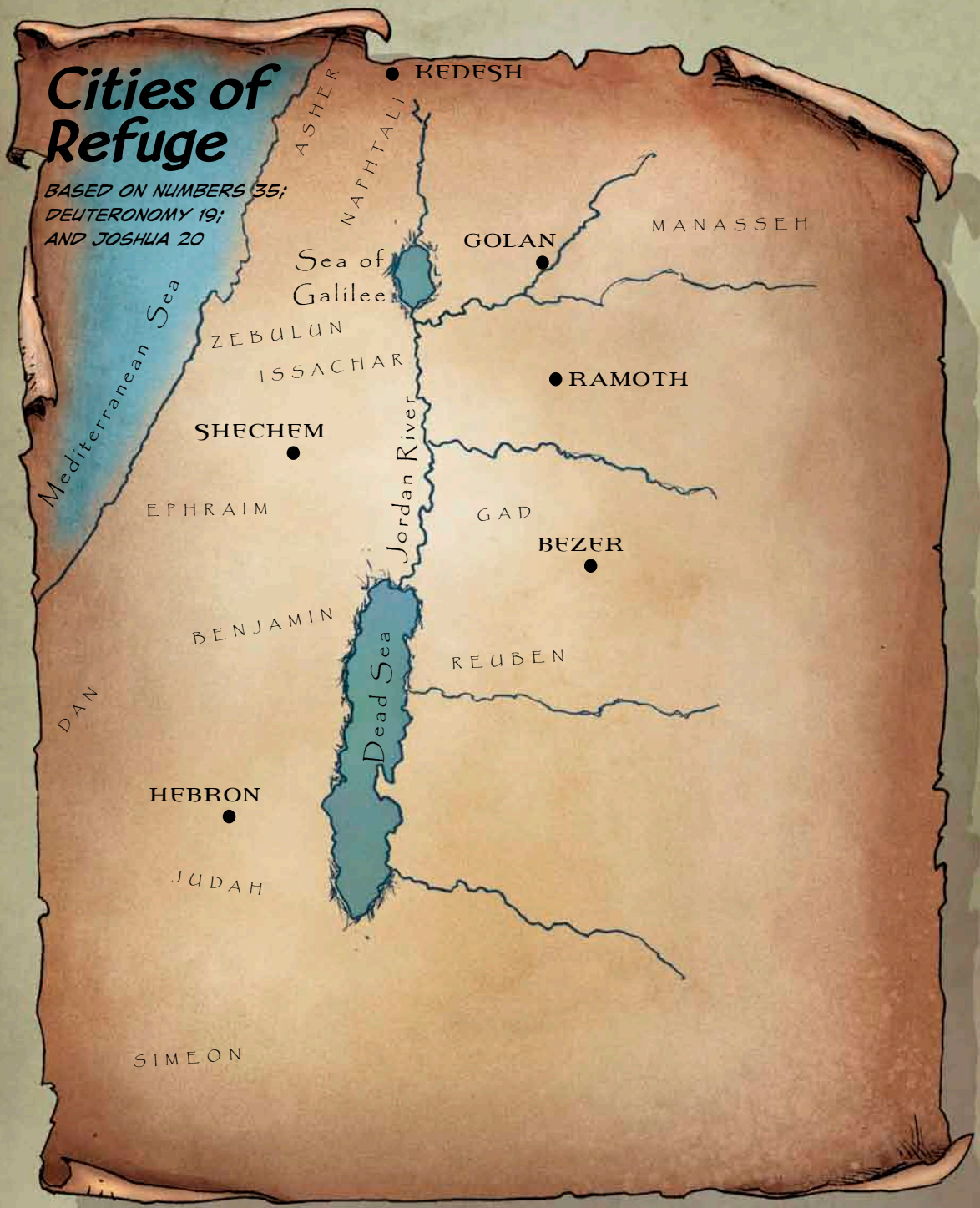








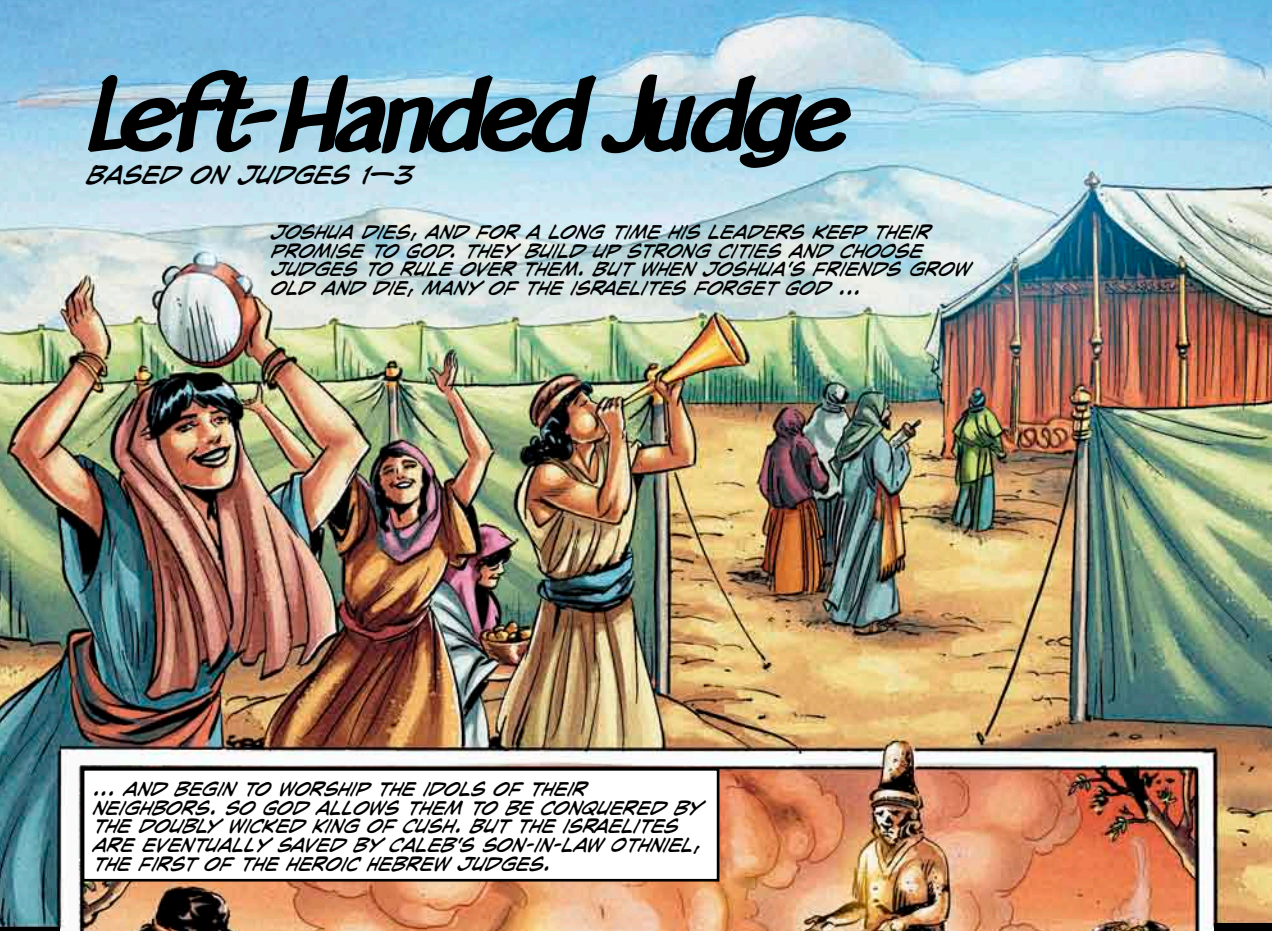
"You know with all your heart and soul that not one of all the good promises the LORD your God gave you has failed. Every promise has been fulfilled; not one has failed."



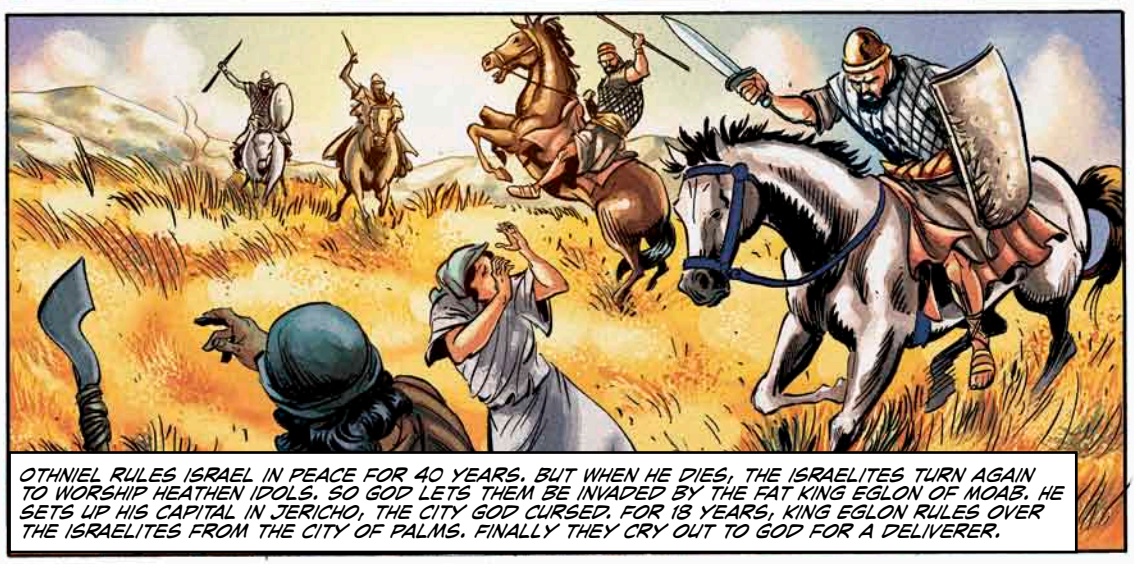
JOSHUA DIVIDES THE LAND AMONG THE TRIBES AND SETS UP SIX CITIES OF REFUGE WHERE PEOPLE CAN GO TO RECEIVE MERCY—EVEN IF THEY DO SOMETHING AS BAD AS KILLING A PERSON.

Left-Handed Judge

BASED ON JUDGES 1–3








GOD HEARS THE ISRAELITES' PRAYERS AND RAISES UP A DELIVERER FROM THE TRIBE OF BENJAMIN—A TRIBE KNOWN FOR BEING LEFT-HANDED. WHEN KING EGLON DEMANDS TRIBUTE FROM THE BENJAMITES, A MAN NAMED EHUD STEPS FORWARD.
LET ME DELIVER THE GOLD TO THIS TYRANT!
HOPEFULLY THEY WON'T SEARCH ME FOR A WEAPON.
IN EGLON'S THRONE ROOM, EHUD DELIVERS THE BENJAMITES' GOLD AND TURNS TO LEAVE.
OH, WAIT! I ALMOST FORGOT. GOD HAS A MESSAGE FOR YOU.
BUT IT'S A SECRET; I HAVE TO TELL YOU PRIVATELY.
EVERYBODY OUT! BUT FIRST, MAKE SURE HE DOESN'T HAVE A WEAPON.
SEARCH HIM!


THE GUARDS SEARCH THE LEFT SIDE OF HIS BODY FOR A WEAPON. BUT THEY DON'T SEARCH HIS OTHER SIDE, NEVER SUSPECTING HE MIGHT BE LEFT-HANDED.
AFTER THE GUARDS LEAVE, EHUD APPROACHES EGLON ON THE THRONE.
THIS IS GOD'S MESSAGE TO YOU!
EHUD STABS KING EGLON IN THE BELLY. BUT EGLON IS SO FAT THAT EHUD CAN'T PULL HIS SWORD BACK OUT. THE FAT OF EGLON'S STOMACH COVERS UP THE HANDLE COMPLETELY.
QUICKLY, EHUD LOCKS THE DOORS OF THE UPPER ROOM AND THEN SNEAKS OUT THROUGH THE SEWER SYSTEM. THE SMELL IN THE ROOM IS SO BAD THAT EGLON'S SERVANTS THINK HE IS GOING TO THE BATHROOM, SO NO ONE DISCOVERS THE ASSASSINATION FOR MANY HOURS.
IN THE MEANTIME, EHUD RALLIES THE ISRAELITES. THEY STAND AT THE FORDS OF THE JORDAN, THE SHALLOWEST PART OF THE RIVER. WITH THE WATER UP TO THEIR KNEES, THEY FIGHT OFF THE MOABITES, KILLING MANY OF THEM.
AFTER THIS VICTORY, THE LAND HAS PEACE FOR 80 YEARS.

The Song of Deborah

BASED ON JUDGES 4–5




THE ANGRY FARMERS TAKE THEIR STORY TO DEBORAH, WHO HOLDS COURT UNDER A PALM TREE IN EPHRAIM.
WHAT CAN WE DO? THE CANAANITES ARE STEALING OUR FOOD.
TAKE A MESSAGE TO CAPTAIN BARAK IN THE NORTH COUNTRY. TELL HIM TO COME AT ONCE.
DOES SHE MEAN WAR?
WE DON'T HAVE A CHANCE AGAINST THE CANAANITES. THEY HAVE 900 IRON CHARIOTS, AND WE HAVE ONLY A FEW CRUDE WEAPONS.
A FEW DAYS LATER ...
BARAK, THIS IS THE PLAN GOD GAVE ME. TAKE 10,000 MEN TO MOUNT TABOR. WHEN KING JABIN HEARS OF THIS, HE WILL ORDER HIS ARMY, UNDER SISERA, TO COME OUT AND DESTROY US. BUT WITH GOD'S HELP YOU WILL DEFEAT THEM.
I'LL LEAD THE ARMY, BUT ONLY IF YOU'LL GO WITH US. GOD SPEAKS THROUGH YOU. AND IF YOU ARE THERE, I KNOW GOD WILL HELP US.


I AM SORRY THAT YOU LACK THE FAITH TO LEAD BY YOURSELF. VERY WELL, I WILL GO WITH YOU. BUT SINCE YOU NEED A WOMAN TO HELP YOU FIGHT YOUR BATTLES, A WOMAN WILL WIN YOUR BATTLE FOR YOU AS WELL.
AFTER A QUICK MARCH, THE ISRAELITES REACH MOUNT TABOR. DEBORAH'S PROPHECY COMES TRUE— THE CANAANITE ARMY COMES TO MEET THEM.
HAVE FAITH! THIS IS THE DAY THE LORD WILL DELIVER US.
DEBORAH GIVES THE SIGNAL, AND BARAK CHARGES DOWN THE MOUNTAIN LEADING HIS TROOPS. ABOVE THEM LIGHTNING FLASHES ...
A CLOUDBURST TURNS THE PLAIN INTO A SEA OF MUD. THE IRON CHARIOTS OF THE CANAANITES SINK INTO THE MIRE. TRAPPED, THEY ARE AT THE MERCY OF THE ISRAELITES, WHO ATTACK WITH SPEED AND COURAGE.


TO THE RIVER!
THE CANAANITES TRY TO RETREAT. BUT THE KISHON RIVER IS ALREADY OVERFLOWING ITS BANKS. AND THE CANAANITES WHO TRY TO SWIM TO SAFETY SINK UNDER THE WEIGHT OF THEIR HEAVY ARMOR.
SISERA TRIES TO ESCAPE. ON THE WAY HE STOPS TO REST IN A TENT THAT HE THINKS IS FRIENDLY. BUT THE WOMAN WHO LIVES THERE, JAEL, IS LOYAL TO ISRAEL AND KILLS SISERA WHILE HE IS ASLEEP.
WHEN DEBORAH LEARNS THAT THE CANAANITES HAVE BEEN DEFEATED, SHE SINGS A SONG OF VICTORY ...
IN THE HEAVENS, EVEN THE STARS FIGHT FOR THE LORD. MAY ALL THE LORD'S ENEMIES PERISH. AND MAY THOSE WHO LOVE THE LORD BE LIKE THE SUN SHINING IN ALL ITS MIGHT.
THE PEOPLE REJOICE AND SING PRAISES TOO. AND FOR 40 YEARS THERE IS PEACE IN ISRAEL. FAMILIES WORK IN THEIR FIELDS AND HARVEST THEIR CROPS. BUT IN TIME THEY AGAIN FORGET GOD AND FIND THEMSELVES IN MORE TROUBLE THAN EVER BEFORE.

Cowardly Judge

BASED ON JUDGES 6–7



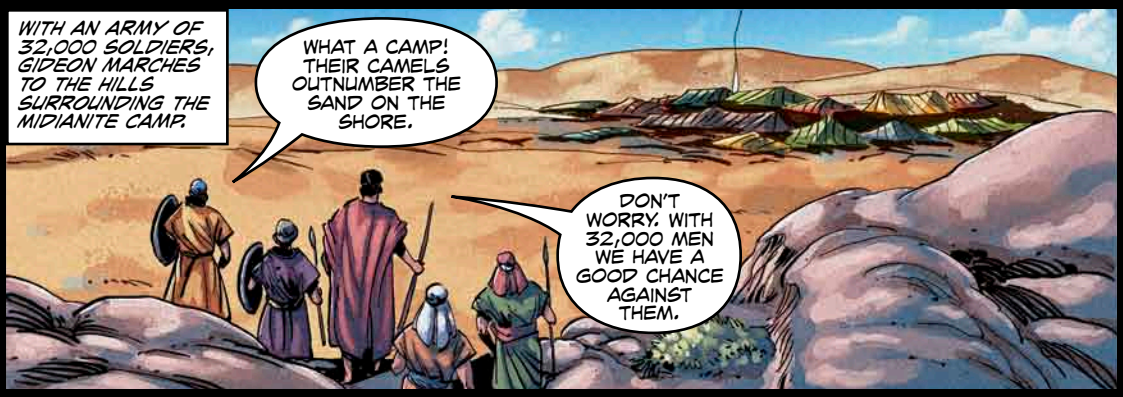



BUT WHEN THE RAID IS OVER ...
IT'S GONE! OUR GRAIN IS GONE!
FOR SEVEN LONG YEARS THE ISRAELITES SUFFER AT THE HANDS OF THE DESERT TRIBESMEN. THEY HIDE OUT IN CAVES AND THRESH THEIR GRAIN IN SECRET PLACES ... BUT THE RAIDERS ALWAYS RETURN.
THEN EVEN MORE FRIGHTENING NEWS COMES ...
THE MIDIANITES ARE COMING AGAIN, AND THEY'RE BRINGING GREAT ARMIES FROM THE EAST.
LIKE GRASSHOPPERS, THE ENEMY SWARMS OVER THE ISRAELITE FIELDS, STEALING GRAIN, CATTLE, AND SHEEP.
ONE DAY A YOUNG ISRAELITE IS SECRETLY THRESHING HIS GRAIN WHEN A STRANGER APPEARS BEFORE HIM.
WHO ARE YOU? WHAT DO YOU WANT?
YOU ARE A MIGHTY WARRIOR, GIDEON. GOD HAS CHOSEN YOU TO SAVE HIS PEOPLE.


ME? MY FAMILY IS THE WEAKEST OF THE WHOLE TRIBE, AND I'M THE WEAKEST ONE IN MY FAMILY. IF YOU'RE REALLY AN ANGEL OF THE LORD, THEN GIVE ME A SIGN.
GIDEON PREPARES SOME FOOD AND BRINGS IT TO THE STRANGER.
PUT THE FOOD ON THE ROCK.
THE STRANGER TOUCHES THE FOOD WITH HIS STAFF. INSTANTLY, A FIRE BURSTS FORTH AND CONSUMES IT.
I HAVE SEEN THE ANGEL OF THE LORD FACE-TO-FACE!
WHEN THE ANGEL DISAPPEARS, GOD SPEAKS TO GIDEON AND TELLS HIM TO DESTROY THE ALTAR OF BAAL.
BUT GIDEON IS AFRAID OF THE TOWNSPEOPLE, SO HE WAITS UNTIL DARK TO OBEY.
WON'T THE PEOPLE KILL US IF THEY FIND OUT?
THAT'S WHY WE'RE DOING THIS AT NIGHT.


BUT GIDEON STILL HOPES THAT GOD HASN'T REALLY CALLED HIM. HE ASKS FOR A SIGN ...
OKAY, GOD, TOMORROW MORNING IF THIS WOOL IS WET WITH DEW AND THE GROUND IS DRY, THEN I'LL KNOW THAT YOU HAVE TRULY CHOSEN ME.
THE NEXT MORNING, GIDEON HAS HIS SIGN.
THE GROUND IS DRY—BUT THERE'S ENOUGH DEW ON THIS WOOL TO FILL A WHOLE BOWL.
BUT GIDEON IS STILL AFRAID.
OH GOD, PLEASE DON'T BE ANGRY, BUT GIVE ME JUST ONE MORE SIGN. THIS TIME MAKE THE WOOL DRY AND THE GROUND WET. THEN I'LL REALLY TRUST IN YOU.
THE NEXT MORNING ...
THE WOOL IS DRY—AND THE GROUND IS WET! ALL RIGHT, GOD, I BELIEVE! NOW I KNOW THAT I AM THE ONE CALLED TO SAVE MY PEOPLE.


GIDEON CALLS THE LEADERS OF ISRAEL TOGETHER.
WITH GOD'S HELP WE CAN DRIVE THE MIDIANITES FROM OUR LAND. ARE YOU WITH ME?
YES!
YES!


WITH AN ARMY OF 32,000 SOLDIERS, GIDEON MARCHES TO THE HILLS SURROUNDING THE MIDIANITE CAMP.
WHAT A CAMP! THEIR CAMELS OUTNUMBER THE SAND ON THE SHORE.
DON'T WORRY. WITH 32,000 MEN WE HAVE A GOOD CHANCE AGAINST THEM.


BUT GOD GIVES GIDEON MORE INSTRUCTIONS.
GOD HAS SAID THAT IF ANY OF YOU IS AFRAID TO FIGHT, YOU MAY LEAVE NOW AND GO HOME.
MOST OF HIS ARMY DISBANDS. ABOUT 10,000 MEN REMAIN.


BUT GOD WANTS IT TO BE CLEAR THAT VICTORY COMES FROM GOD, NOT THE STRENGTH OF GIDEON'S ARMY. HE MAKES GIDEON WEED OUT HIS ARMY ONCE AGAIN. WHEN THE MEN STOP TO DRINK FROM A BROOK, ANYONE WHO KNEELS DOWN TO DRINK IS SENT HOME.
HOW CAN I WIN A BATTLE WITH SO FEW SOLDIERS?


ONLY 300 MEN ARE LEFT OUT OF GIDEON'S ORIGINAL ARMY OF 32,000. NOW THE ISRAELITES KNOW BEYOND ALL DOUBT THAT ONLY WITH GOD'S HELP CAN THEY DEFEAT THE ENEMY.
HIDE YOUR TORCHES IN THESE PITCHERS. SPREAD OUT ON THREE SIDES OF THE CAMP. WAIT UNTIL NIGHTFALL, THEN LISTEN FOR MY SIGNAL ON THE TRUMPET.
WE'RE READY!
AT GIDEON'S SIGNAL, THE MEN BLOW THEIR TRUMPETS, SMASH THEIR PITCHERS, WAVE THEIR TORCHES, AND GIVE THE BATTLE CRY ...
THE SWORD OF THE LORD AND OF GIDEON!
THE STILLNESS OF THE NIGHT IS SUDDENLY BROKEN BY THE BLARE OF 300 TRUMPETS AND THE CRASH OF BROKEN PITCHERS. STARTLED FROM THEIR SLEEP, THE MIDIANITES RUSH OUT TO FIND THEIR CAMP ABLAZE WITH FLAMING TORCHES.
THOUGH THEY ARE ONLY 300, THE ISRAELITES' TORCHES, HORNS, AND SHOUTING THROW THE MIDIANITES INTO A PANIC. THEY LASH OUT WITH THEIR SWORDS, STRIKING EACH OTHER DOWN. WITHIN MINUTES THEY'VE KILLED MORE OF THEIR OWN MEN THAN GIDEON EVER COULD WITH HIS ORIGINAL ARMY. THE LORD HAS DEMONSTRATED HIS MIGHT ONCE AGAIN.

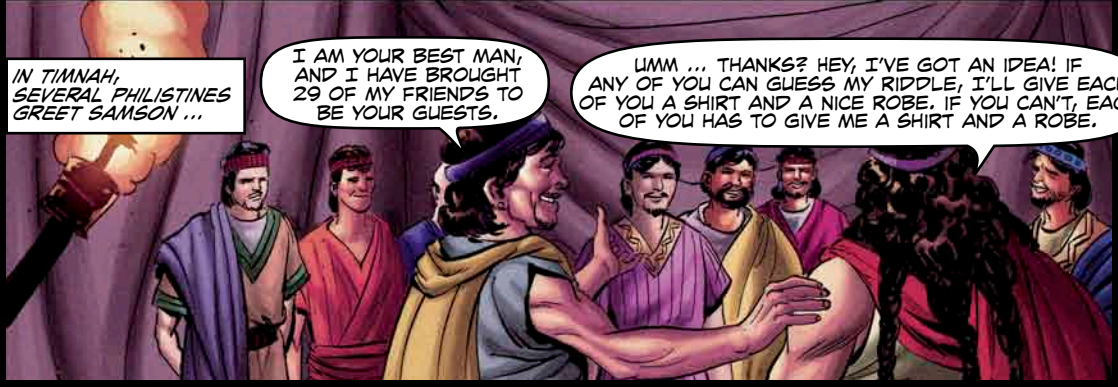
God's Enforcer

BASED ON JUDGES 13–14

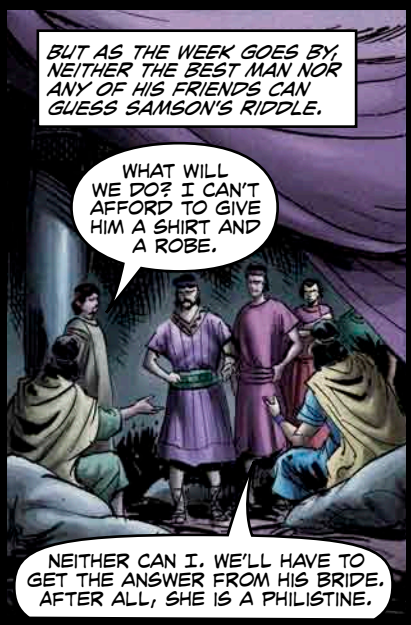


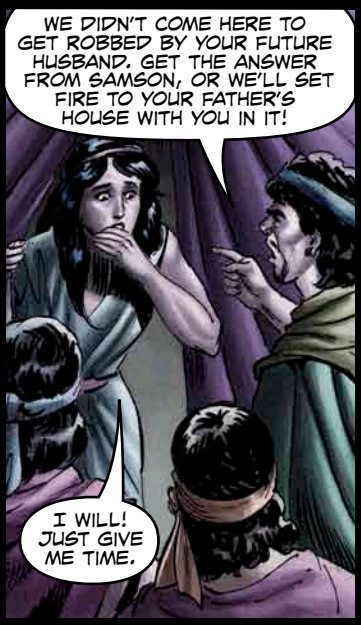

WE HAVE SEEN GOD!
THE LORD WILL SURELY FULFILL HIS PROMISE TO US.
BUT TO HIS PARENTS' DISMAY, AS THEIR SON, SAMSON, GROWS UP, HE DOESN'T ACT LIKE SOMEONE DESTINED TO BE GOD'S HERO. AN IRRESPONSIBLE YOUNG MAN, HE DISOBEYS MANY OF THE LORD'S COMMANDS, EXCEPT FOR THE ONE ABOUT CUTTING HIS HAIR.
MAY I GIVE YOU A DRINK OF WATER?
YES, THANK YOU.
SHE'S THE MOST BEAUTIFUL GIRL I'VE EVER SEEN. I DON'T CARE IF SHE'S A PHILISTINE, THE ENEMY OF MY PEOPLE.
BACK HOME, SAMSON LOSES NO TIME TELLING HIS PARENTS WHAT HE WANTS.
I HAVE FALLEN IN LOVE WITH A PHILISTINE GIRL. MAKE ARRANGEMENTS WITH HER PARENTS FOR US TO GET MARRIED.
BUT YOU'RE SUPPOSED TO BE GOD'S DELIVERER!
HOW CAN YOU LOVE ONE OF OUR ENEMIES? SHE DOESN'T BELIEVE IN OUR GOD.
I DON'T CARE. MAKE IT HAPPEN.

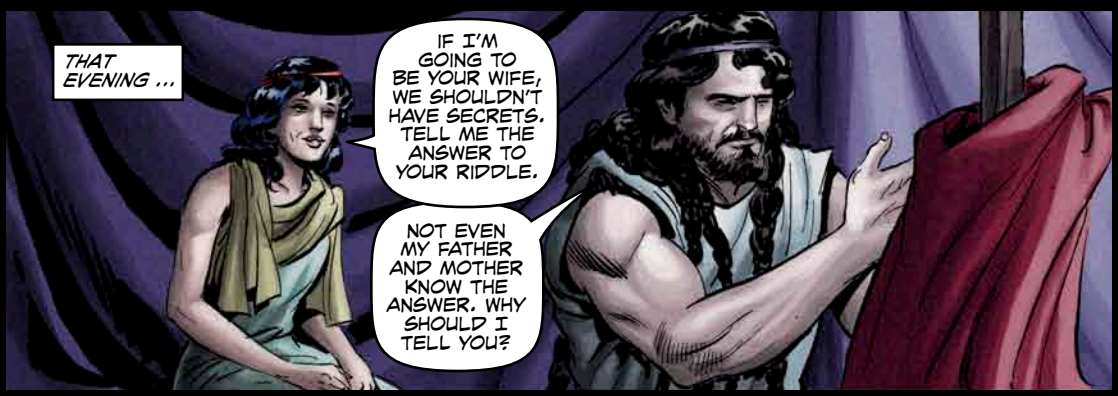

ON HIS WAY TO VISIT HIS NEW FIANCÉE, SAMSON IS SUDDENLY ATTACKED BY A LION!
GRRRR
ROAR
AT THAT MOMENT, THE SPIRIT OF THE LORD GIVES SAMSON GREAT POWER, AND HE RIPS THE LION APART WITH HIS BARE HANDS!
THE LORD HAS GIVEN ME GREAT STRENGTH. NOBODY BETTER MESS WITH ME NOW.
FINALLY, THE TIME FOR THE WEDDING COMES. SAMSON WALKS BY THE SPOT OF HIS BATTLE WITH THE LION AND SEES ITS BODY STILL THERE.
BEES HAVE MADE HONEY IN THE LION'S CARCASS.
SAMSON SCOOPS SOME OF THE HONEY AND TASTES IT.
IT'S GOOD. HA! I'M EATING FOOD OUT OF THE ANIMAL THAT WANTED TO EAT ME FOR FOOD.


IN TIMNAH, SEVERAL PHILISTINES GREET SAMSON ...
I AM YOUR BEST MAN, AND I HAVE BROUGHT 29 OF MY FRIENDS TO BE YOUR GUESTS.
UMM ... THANKS? HEY, I'VE GOT AN IDEA! IF ANY OF YOU CAN GUESS MY RIDDLE, I'LL GIVE EACH OF YOU A SHIRT AND A NICE ROBE. IF YOU CAN'T, EACH OF YOU HAS TO GIVE ME A SHIRT AND A ROBE.


AT LEAST ONE OF US SHOULD BE ABLE TO FIGURE OUT THIS STUPID ISRAELITE'S RIDDLE.
IT'S A BET!
"OUT OF THE EATER, SOMETHING TO EAT. OUT OF THE STRONG, SOMETHING SWEET." YOU MUST GUESS THE ANSWER WITHIN THE SEVEN DAYS OF MY WEDDING FEAST.

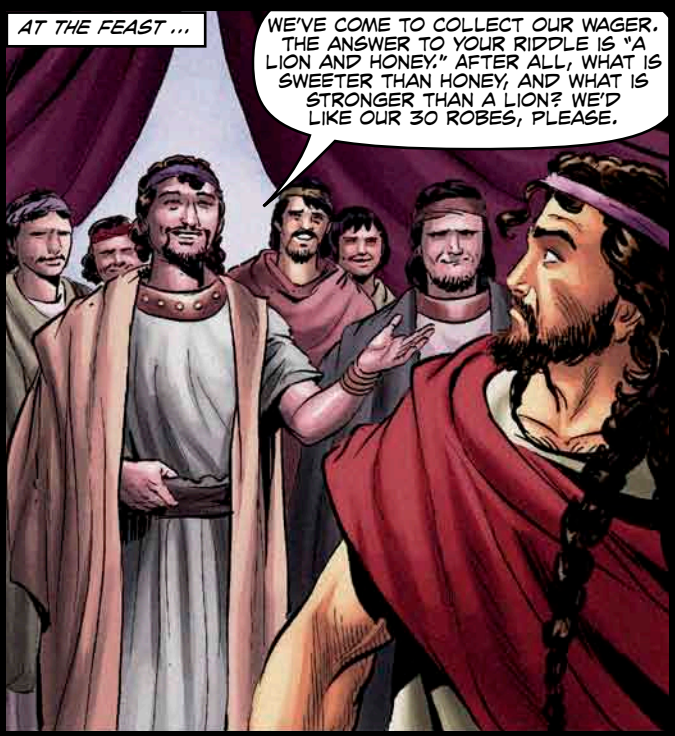

BUT AS THE WEEK GOES BY, NEITHER THE BEST MAN NOR ANY OF HIS FRIENDS CAN GUESS SAMSON'S RIDDLE.
WHAT WILL WE DO? I CAN'T AFFORD TO GIVE HIM A SHIRT AND A ROBE.
NEITHER CAN I. WE'LL HAVE TO GET THE ANSWER FROM HIS BRIDE. AFTER ALL, SHE IS A PHILISTINE.


WE DIDN'T COME HERE TO GET ROBBED BY YOUR FUTURE HUSBAND. GET THE ANSWER FROM SAMSON, OR WE'LL SET FIRE TO YOUR FATHER'S HOUSE WITH YOU IN IT!
I WILL! JUST GIVE ME TIME.


THAT EVENING ...
IF I'M GOING TO BE YOUR WIFE, WE SHOULDN'T HAVE SECRETS. TELL ME THE ANSWER TO YOUR RIDDLE.
NOT EVEN MY FATHER AND MOTHER KNOW THE ANSWER. WHY SHOULD I TELL YOU?


BUT SHE CRIES EVERY DAY, AND ON THE LAST DAY OF THE FEAST ...
YOU HATE ME! IF YOU LOVED ME, YOU'D TELL ME THE ANSWER.
FINE! THE ANSWER IS "A LION AND HONEY."


A FEW MINUTES LATER, SHE SLIPS AWAY ...
I HAVE THE ANSWER.
TELL US, AND YOU'LL SAVE YOUR LIFE.


AT THE FEAST ...
WE'VE COME TO COLLECT OUR WAGER. THE ANSWER TO YOUR RIDDLE IS "A LION AND HONEY." AFTER ALL, WHAT IS SWEETER THAN HONEY, AND WHAT IS STRONGER THAN A LION? WE'D LIKE OUR 30 ROBES, PLEASE.

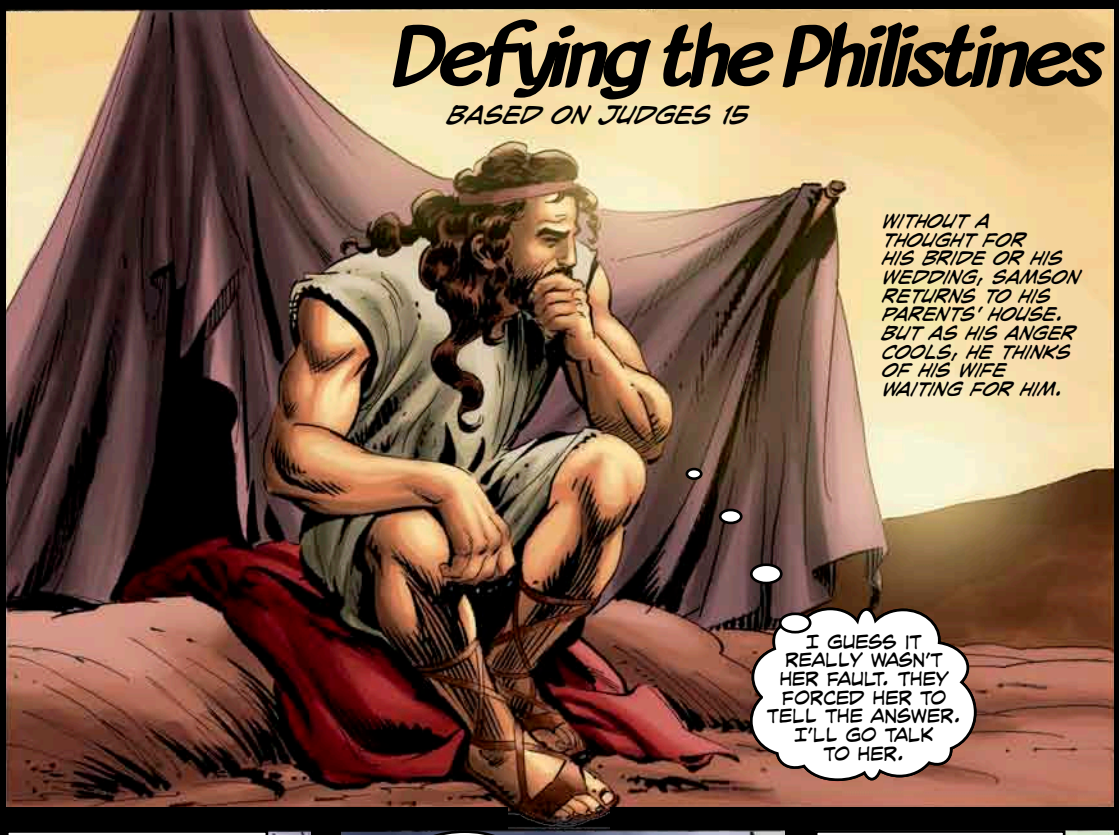

YOU CHEATED. MY BRIDE MUST HAVE TOLD YOU! I MAY HAVE LOST THIS BET, BUT YOUR PEOPLE WILL BE THE ONES TO PAY!


SAMSON IS FURIOUS! HE STORMS OUT OF HIS OWN WEDDING FEAST AND ENTERS ANOTHER CITY.
AH! ENOUGH PHILISTINES TO PAY MY DEBT—AND ALL OF THEM HANDSOMELY DRESSED TOO!


WITH HIS GREAT STRENGTH, SAMSON STRIKES DOWN A GROUP OF ENEMY PHILISTINES.
23 ... 24 ... 25 ...
STILL IN A RAGE, SAMSON RETURNS TO THE WEDDING FEAST.
HERE! THE DEBT IS PAID. AND BY THE LIVES OF YOUR OWN COUNTRYMEN!

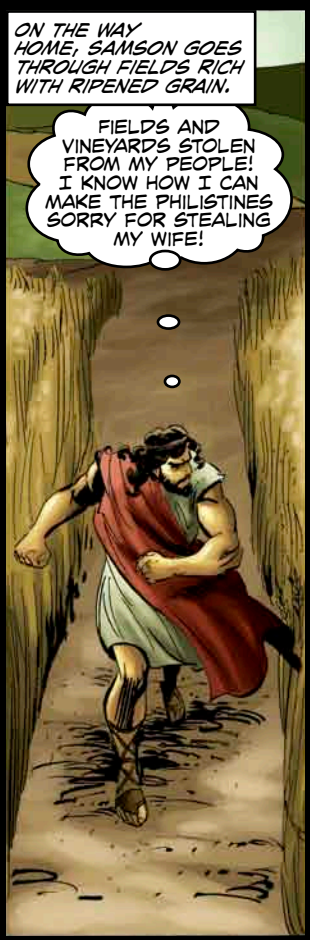
Defying the Philistines

BASED ON JUDGES 15

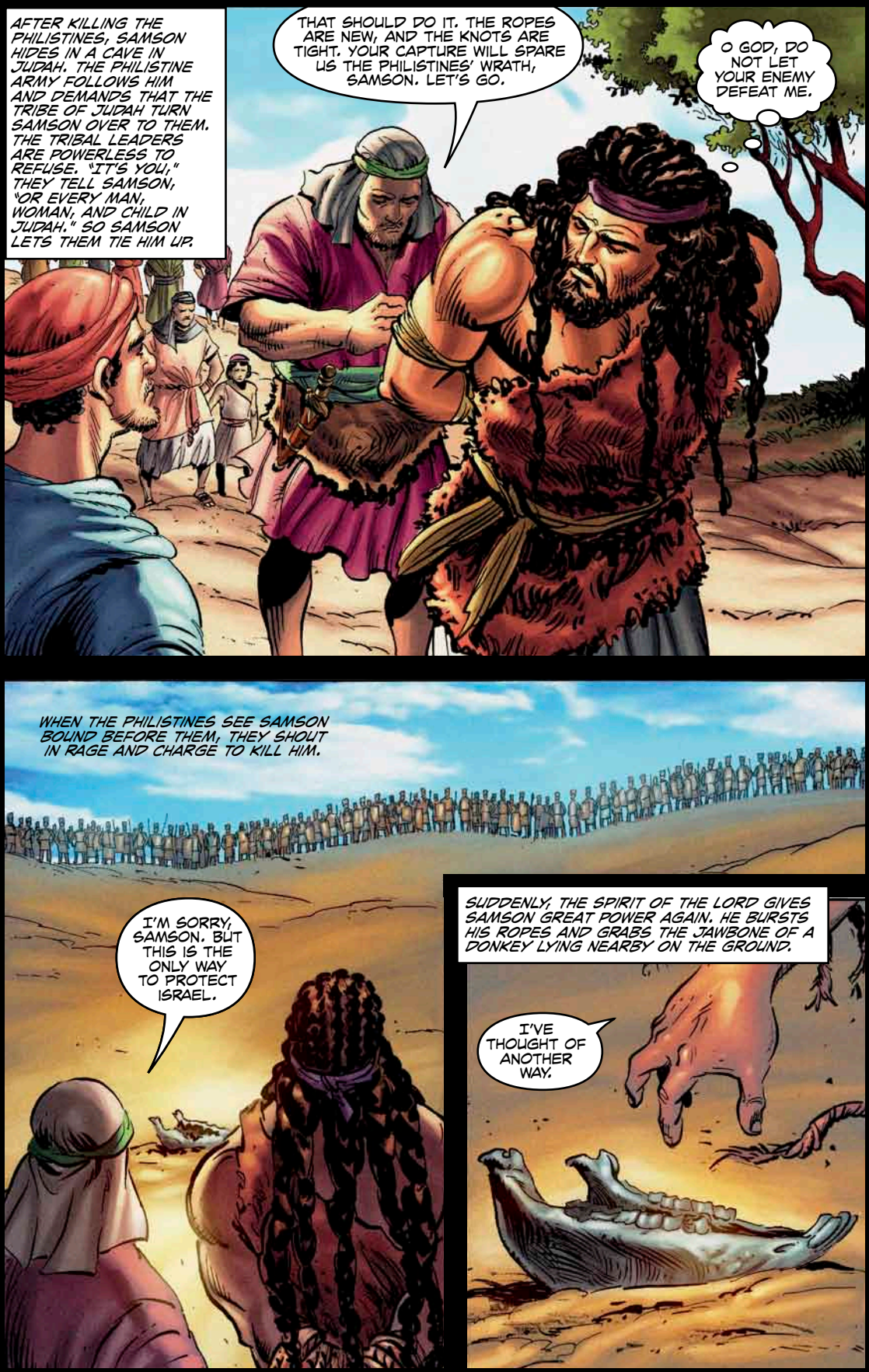




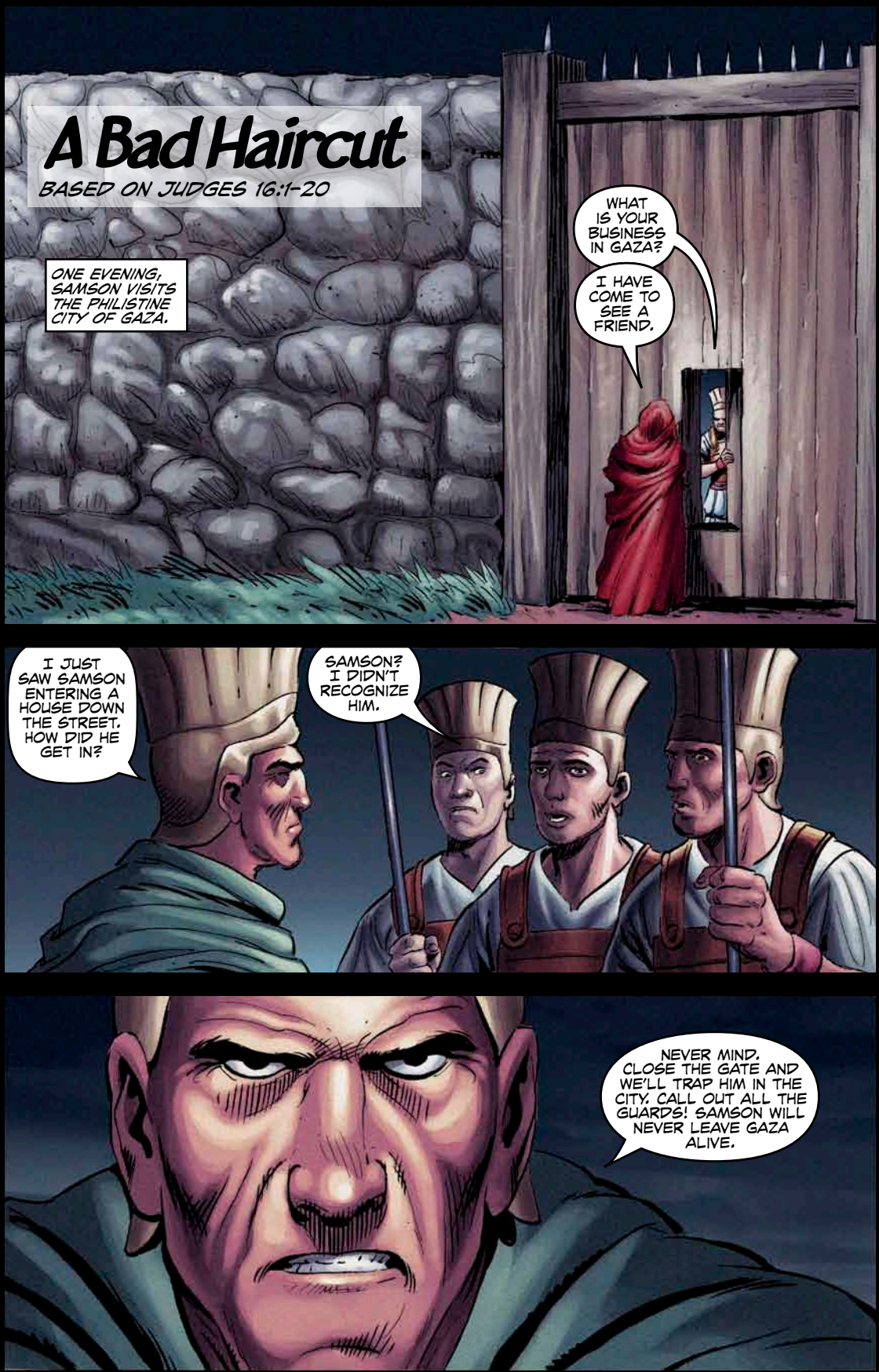





IN NO TIME, SAMSON SETS FOXES RACING THROUGH THE FIELDS AND VINEYARDS WITH FLAMING TORCHES TIED TO THEIR TAILS. IN A MATTER OF MINUTES, THE WHOLE COUNTRYSIDE IS ABLAZE.
IN THE CITY, THE PHILISTINES WATCH WITH TERROR AS THE SKY GLOWS RED.
SAMSON DID THIS! HE'S GETTING EVEN WITH HIS WIFE'S FATHER FOR LETTING HER MARRY SOMEONE ELSE.
HER FATHER SHOULD HAVE KNOWN BETTER THAN TO TRICK SAMSON. COME ON, LET'S GIVE OUR COUNTRYMAN A TASTE OF HIS OWN MEDICINE.
THE ANGRY PHILISTINES SET FIRE TO THE HOME OF SAMSON'S FATHER-IN-LAW. BUT THEY DON'T COUNT ON SAMSON'S RETURN.
YOU KILLED MY WIFE? SHE WAS ONE OF YOUR OWN PEOPLE!
SOMEONE HAD TO BE PUNISHED.
THEN IT WILL BE YOU! NONE OF YOU PHILISTINES DESERVES TO LIVE!


AFTER KILLING THE PHILISTINES, SAMSON HIDES IN A CAVE IN JUDAH. THE PHILISTINE ARMY FOLLOWS HIM AND DEMANDS THAT THE TRIBE OF JUDAH TURN SAMSON OVER TO THEM. THE TRIBAL LEADERS ARE POWERLESS TO REFUSE. "IT'S YOU," THEY TELL SAMSON, "OR EVERY MAN, WOMAN, AND CHILD IN JUDAH." SO SAMSON LETS THEM TIE HIM UP.
THAT SHOULD DO IT. THE ROPES ARE NEW, AND THE KNOTS ARE TIGHT. YOUR CAPTURE WILL SPARE US THE PHILISTINES' WRATH, SAMSON. LET'S GO.
O GOD, DO NOT LET YOUR ENEMY DEFEAT ME.
WHEN THE PHILISTINES SEE SAMSON BOUND BEFORE THEM, THEY SHOUT IN RAGE AND CHARGE TO KILL HIM.
I'M SORRY, SAMSON. BUT THIS IS THE ONLY WAY TO PROTECT ISRAEL.
SUDDENLY, THE SPIRIT OF THE LORD GIVES SAMSON GREAT POWER AGAIN. HE BURSTS HIS ROPES AND GRABS THE JAWBONE OF A DONKEY LYING NEARBY ON THE GROUND.
I'VE THOUGHT OF ANOTHER WAY.

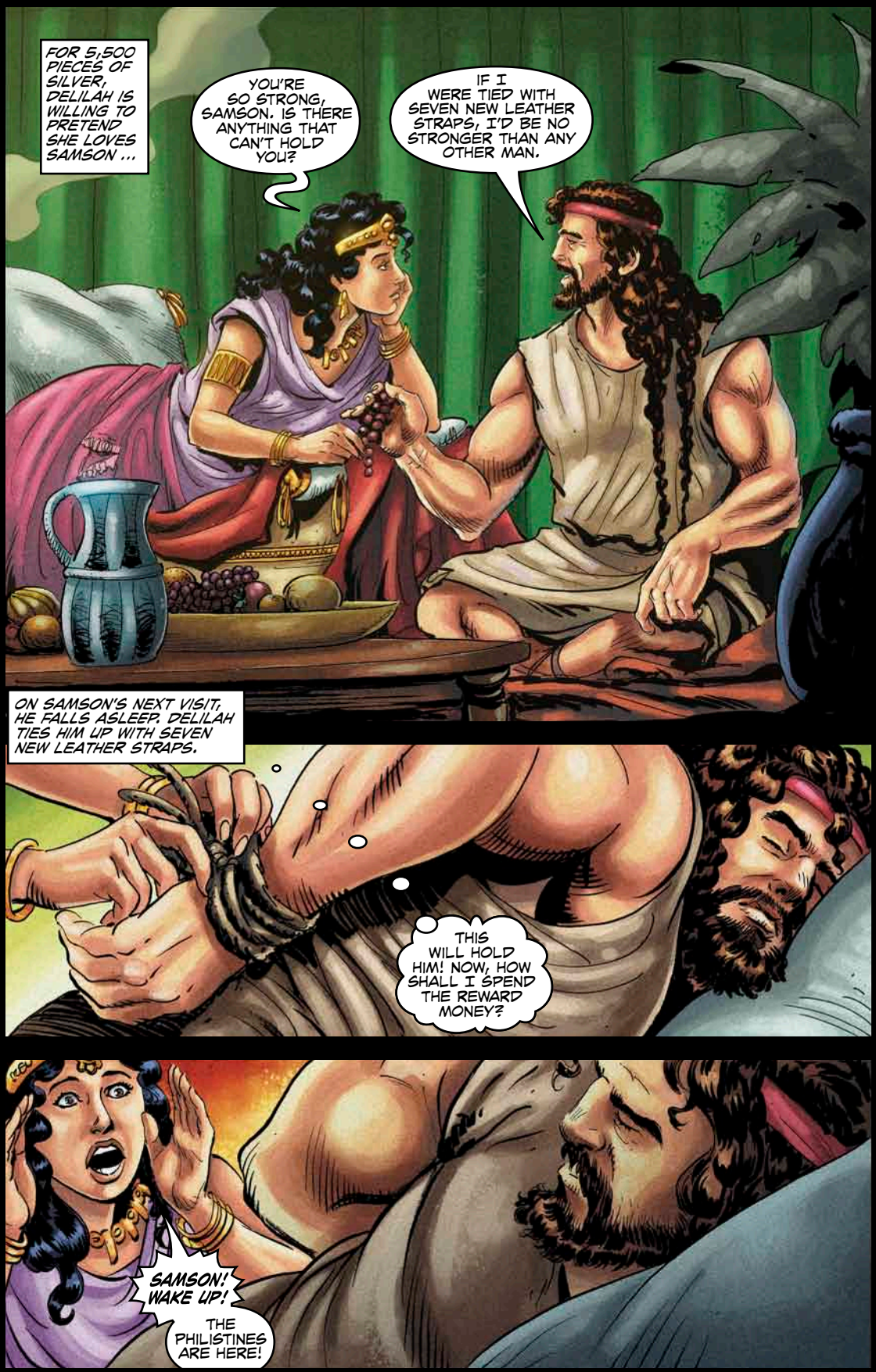

WITH DEADLY AIM, SAMSON STRIKES DOWN ONE PHILISTINE SOLDIER AFTER ANOTHER. THOSE WHO CAN ESCAPE RUN FOR THEIR LIVES.
WHEN HE IS DONE, A THOUSAND PHILISTINES LIE DEAD AROUND HIM.
THEN, WEARY AND THIRSTY, SAMSON PRAYS TO GOD.
LORD, YOU GAVE ME THE VICTORY. DON'T LET ME DIE OF THIRST NOW.
GOD PROVIDES A STREAM OF WATER TO STRENGTHEN SAMSON. AFTER THIS EVENT, SAMSON SERVES AS A LEADER AND PROTECTOR OF ISRAEL FOR 20 YEARS.


A Bad Haircut
BASED ON JUDGES 16:1-20
ONE EVENING, SAMSON VISITS THE PHILISTINE CITY OF GAZA.
WHAT IS YOUR BUSINESS IN GAZA?
I HAVE COME TO SEE A FRIEND.
I JUST SAW SAMSON ENTERING A HOUSE DOWN THE STREET. HOW DID HE GET IN?
SAMSON? I DIDN'T RECOGNIZE HIM.
NEVER MIND. CLOSE THE GATE AND WE'LL TRAP HIM IN THE CITY. CALL OUT ALL THE GUARDS! SAMSON WILL NEVER LEAVE GAZA ALIVE.

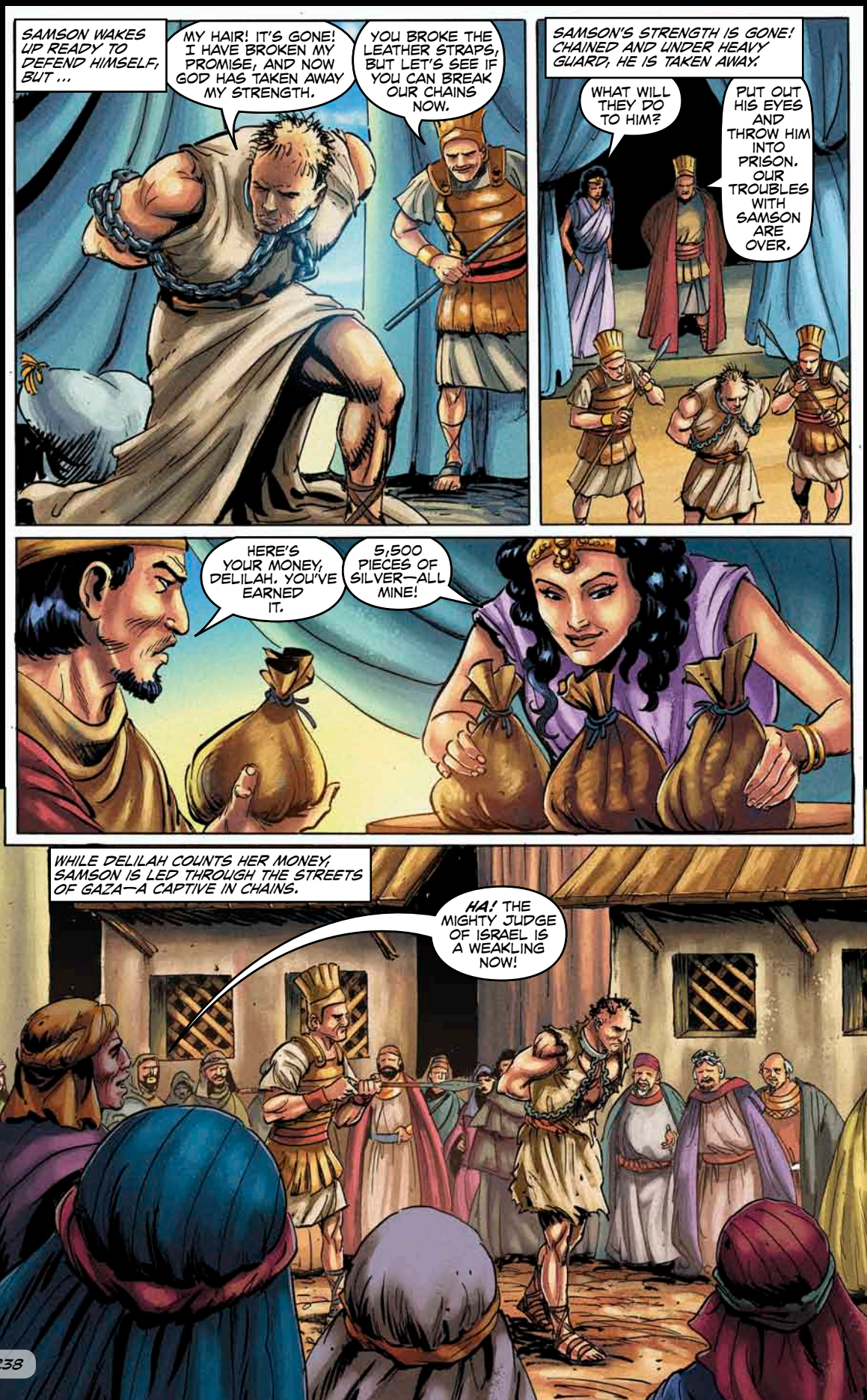

THE PHILISTINES CALL OUT ALL THE GUARDS AND LIE IN WAIT FOR SAMSON.
I'VE NEVER SEEN SAMSON. WHAT IS HE LIKE?
OH, HE'S LIKE ANYONE ELSE— IF YOU DON'T COUNT THE FACT THAT HE HAS HAIR LIKE THICK VINES AND THE STRENGTH OF A HUNDRED MEN.
AT MIDNIGHT, SAMSON WALKS DOWN THE STREET AND TOWARD THE GATE ...
HMM. LOTS OF GUARDS ON DUTY TONIGHT. THEY'RE PROBABLY NOT HERE TO HELP ME THROUGH THE GATE, SO ...
I'LL HELP MYSELF!
STOP HIM! DON'T LET HIM GET AWAY.


WHO CAN STOP A MAN STRONG ENOUGH TO CARRY THE CITY GATE? I TELL YOU—
—HIS STRENGTH IS NOT HUMAN!
NEWS OF SAMSON'S ESCAPE FROM GAZA SPREADS THROUGH THE COUNTRY. RULERS OF PHILISTINE CITIES ARE WORRIED AND CALL A MEETING.
SAMSON MUST BE CAPTURED. LET'S PUT ALL OUR ARMIES TOGETHER.
I'M NOT RISKING MY ARMY ON SAMSON. WE'VE GOT TO FIND ANOTHER WAY.
I HAVE AN IDEA!
WE KNOW SAMSON HAS MORE THAN MORTAL STRENGTH. IF WE CAN LEARN THE SOURCE OF THAT STRENGTH ...


DO YOU THINK HE'S GOING TO TELL US WHAT IT IS?
NO, BUT HE'LL TELL THE RIGHT PERSON. I HEAR HE'S IN LOVE WITH DELILAH ...
DELILAH? SHE'S A PHILISTINE.
RIGHT. SHE'LL GET SAMSON TO TELL HER HIS SECRET. THEN SHE'LL TELL US.
WILL SHE? WHAT IF SHE'S IN LOVE WITH SAMSON?
SHE'S ALSO IN LOVE WITH MONEY. COME ON. LET'S GO SEE HER.
SO THE PHILISTINE RULERS VISIT DELILAH.
IF YOU FIND OUT SAMSON'S SECRET FOR US, WE'LL GIVE YOU 1,100 PIECES OF SILVER. EACH.
PAYABLE WHEN YOU DELIVER SAMSON INTO OUR HANDS.
HMM ... 1,100 TIMES FIVE EQUALS ... UMM, A LOT OF MONEY. HOW CAN I REFUSE?
THIS AMOUNT OF MONEY IS A SMALL FORTUNE. IF SHE CAN FIND OUT SAMSON'S WEAKNESS, DELILAH WILL BE AS RICH AS A MODERN MILLIONAIRE.


FOR 5,500 PIECES OF SILVER, DELILAH IS WILLING TO PRETEND SHE LOVES SAMSON ...
YOU'RE SO STRONG, SAMSON. IS THERE ANYTHING THAT CAN'T HOLD YOU?
IF I WERE TIED WITH SEVEN NEW LEATHER STRAPS, I'D BE NO STRONGER THAN ANY OTHER MAN.
ON SAMSON'S NEXT VISIT, HE FALLS ASLEEP. DELILAH TIES HIM UP WITH SEVEN NEW LEATHER STRAPS.
THIS WILL HOLD HIM! NOW, HOW SHALL I SPEND THE REWARD MONEY?
SAMSON! WAKE UP!
THE PHILISTINES ARE HERE!


SAMSON TRICKED ME!
WHY DID YOU TIE ME UP?
OH, JUST A GIRLISH WHIM. I WANTED TO SEE IF YOU WERE TELLING ME THE TRUTH.
DELILAH KEEPS TRYING TO LEARN THE SECRET OF SAMSON'S STRENGTH. SHE BINDS HIM IN DIFFERENT WAYS, BUT EACH TIME HE BREAKS FREE. AT LAST ...,
YOU DON'T LOVE ME! IF YOU DID, YOU WOULD TELL ME YOUR TRUE WEAKNESS.
DON'T CRY—I'LL TELL YOU MY SECRET. WHEN I WAS DEDICATED TO GOD, A PROMISE WAS MADE NEVER TO CUT MY HAIR. IF I BREAK THAT PROMISE, GOD WILL TAKE AWAY MY STRENGTH. I'LL BE AS WEAK AS ANY OTHER MAN.
AT LAST DELILAH HAS THE REAL SECRET. SHE CALLS THE PHILISTINES AND THEY PLAN TO TRAP SAMSON THAT NIGHT.
HAVE YOUR CHAINS READY—AND BRING THE MONEY YOU PROMISED ME.
THAT EVENING, SAMSON CALLS ON DELILAH. WHEN HE FALLS ASLEEP ...
NOW'S YOUR CHANCE.
I'VE NEVER SEEN SUCH LONG HAIR. BUT I STILL DON'T SEE HOW THIS WILL TAKE HIS STRENGTH AWAY.
SAMSON! WAKE UP!
THE PHILISTINES ARE HERE!


SAMSON WAKES UP READY TO DEFEND HIMSELF, BUT ...
MY HAIR! IT'S GONE! I HAVE BROKEN MY PROMISE, AND NOW GOD HAS TAKEN AWAY MY STRENGTH.
YOU BROKE THE LEATHER STRAPS, BUT LET'S SEE IF YOU CAN BREAK OUR CHAINS NOW.
SAMSON'S STRENGTH IS GONE! CHAINED AND UNDER HEAVY GUARD, HE IS TAKEN AWAY.
WHAT WILL THEY DO TO HIM?
PUT OUT HIS EYES AND THROW HIM INTO PRISON. OUR TROUBLES WITH SAMSON ARE OVER.
HERE'S YOUR MONEY, DELILAH. YOU'VE EARNED IT.
5,500 PIECES OF SILVER—ALL MINE!
WHILE DELILAH COUNTS HER MONEY, SAMSON IS LED THROUGH THE STREETS OF GAZA—A CAPTIVE IN CHAINS.
HA! THE MIGHTY JUDGE OF ISRAEL IS A WEAKLING NOW!

Bringing Down the House

BASED ON JUDGES 16:21-30




SO SAMSON IS BROUGHT OUT OF THE PRISON AND LED UP THE TEMPLE STEPS.
BRING HIM UP HERE SO EVERYONE CAN SEE WHAT THE MIGHTY JUDGE OF ISRAEL LOOKS LIKE NOW.

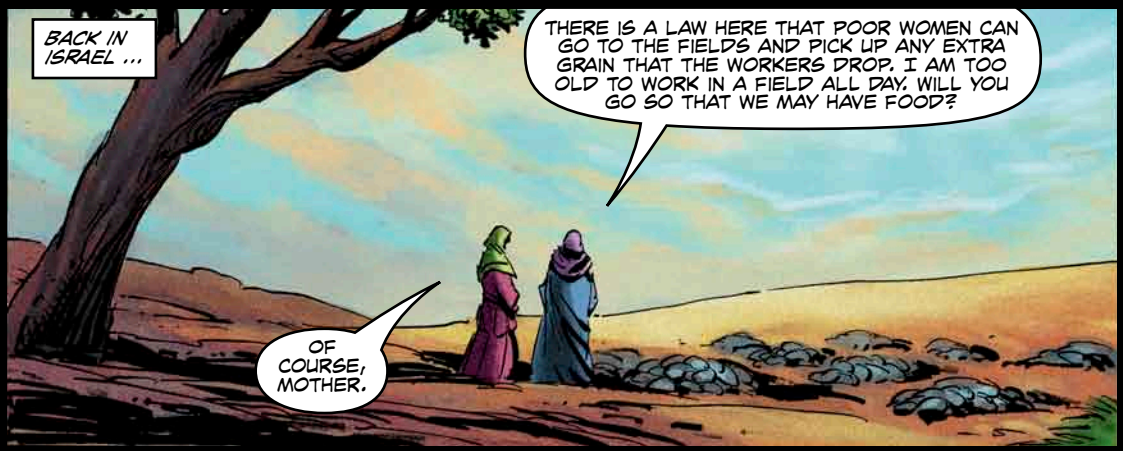

SHOW US HOW YOU CARRIED OFF THE GATES OF GAZA!
LET'S SEE YOU TEAR APART A LION WITH YOUR BARE HANDS NOW!


NOW THAT SAMSON'S HAIR HAS GROWN BACK, HE HOPES THAT GOD WILL RESTORE HIS STRENGTH.
WHERE ARE THE PILLARS? I WANT TO LEAN AGAINST THEM.
HERE, I'LL PUT YOUR HANDS ON THEM.


RUN, BOY, AND DON'T STOP UNTIL YOU'RE OUTSIDE THE TEMPLE.


O GOD, YOU BLESSED ME WITH GREAT STRENGTH ONCE. I IGNORED YOUR COMMANDS AND LOST YOUR BLESSING. I DESERVE TO DIE. BUT JUST LET ME TAKE SOME PHILISTINES WITH ME.
USING ALL HIS STRENGTH, SAMSON PUSHES AGAINST THE PILLARS—AND THE GIANT TEMPLE TO THE HEATHEN GOD DAGON CRASHES TO THE GROUND. CRUSHED BENEATH IT ARE THOUSANDS OF PHILISTINES WHO HAD MADE SLAVES OF SAMSON'S PEOPLE.
KA-BOOM
SAMSON HAD GREAT STRENGTH, BUT A WEAK CHARACTER. YET GOD USED HIM TO HELP ISRAEL ANYWAY. NOW GOD WANTS TO SHOW THAT HE CAN ALSO USE SOMEONE WHO IS PHYSICALLY HELPLESS, BUT NOBLE AND FAITHFUL ...


Ruth's Redeemer
BASED ON RUTH
TWO WOMEN LIVE IN A FOREIGN LAND—NAOMI, A JEW, AND HER DAUGHTER-IN-LAW, RUTH, A MOABITE. ALL THE MEN IN THEIR FAMILY HAVE DIED, AND THEY ARE LEFT PENNILESS AND IN NEED.
LEAVE ME, RUTH. I HAVE NOTHING LEFT. I AM OLD. YOUR BEST HOPE IS TO FIND A HUSBAND WHO CAN TAKE CARE OF YOU.
NO, YOU ARE MY MOTHER. WHERE YOU GO, I WILL GO. YOUR PEOPLE WILL BE MY PEOPLE. AND YOUR GOD WILL BE MY GOD. HE WILL TAKE CARE OF US BETTER THAN ANY HUSBAND.
HE DIDN'T TAKE CARE OF MY HUSBAND. MY NAME MEANS "SWEET," AND FOR A WHILE MY LIFE WAS SWEET. BUT NOW THAT GOD HAS ABANDONED ME, THE NAME "BITTER" WOULD BETTER DESCRIBE ME.
COME, WE WILL GO BACK TO ISRAEL, WHERE I HAVE RELATIVES WHO MAY HELP TAKE CARE OF US.


BACK IN ISRAEL ...
THERE IS A LAW HERE THAT POOR WOMEN CAN GO TO THE FIELDS AND PICK UP ANY EXTRA GRAIN THAT THE WORKERS DROP. I AM TOO OLD TO WORK IN A FIELD ALL DAY. WILL YOU GO SO THAT WE MAY HAVE FOOD?
OF COURSE, MOTHER.


RUTH GOES TO A FIELD OWNED BY BOAZ, A DISTANT RELATIVE OF NAOMI'S. SHE WORKS HARD THERE, GATHERING THE UNUSED GRAIN.


ONE DAY, THE OWNER ARRIVES ...
HOW ARE THE BEST WORKERS IN ALL ISRAEL DOING? THE LORD BLESS YOU AND KEEP YOU!


WHAT A GODLY OWNER.
AND THE LORD BE WITH YOU!


BOAZ QUESTIONS HIS FOREMAN ABOUT PROGRESS ON HIS FIELDS.
... AND ARE YOU TAKING CARE OF THE POOR WOMEN?
YES, AND THERE IS A NEW WIDOW, RUTH FROM MOAB. SHE HAS BEEN LABORING HARD FOR WEEKS TO SUPPORT HER MOTHER-IN-LAW, NAOMI.
NAOMI IS ONE OF MY RELATIVES!

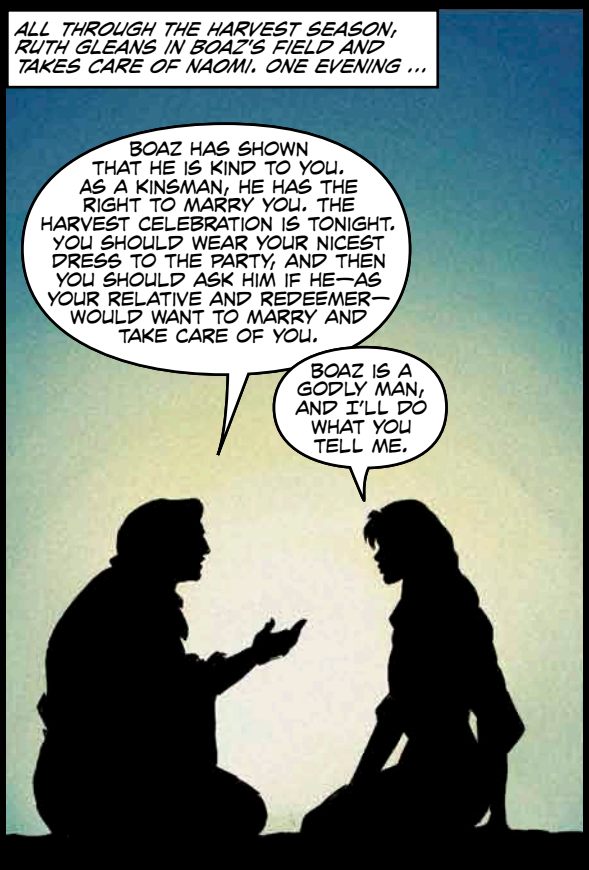

I HAVE HEARD HOW KIND YOU ARE TO YOUR MOTHER-IN-LAW. GLEAN IN MY FIELDS AS MUCH AS YOU LIKE, AND MAY GOD REWARD AND PROTECT YOU.
HE DOES. THANK YOU FOR YOUR KINDNESS.


AT LUNCHTIME, BOAZ IS IMPRESSED WITH RUTH'S FAITH AND WIT.


WHEN THE MEAL IS OVER AND RUTH HAS GONE BACK TO WORK ...
DROP SOME GRAIN ON PURPOSE FOR HER TO PICK UP. MAKE SURE NO HARM COMES TO HER.
DON'T WORRY, BOAZ. SHE WILL BE SAFE, AND SHE'LL FIND ALL THE GRAIN SHE NEEDS.


THAT EVENING ...
LOOK AT ALL THE GRAIN I GOT! NAOMI, YOUR GOD IS GOOD TO US!
WHEN MY HUSBAND AND SONS DIED, I THOUGHT GOD HAD FORGOTTEN ME. NOW I KNOW HOW MUCH HE LOVES ME, BECAUSE HE GAVE ME A DAUGHTER-IN-LAW WHO CARES FOR ME LIKE A DAUGHTER.


I MET THE OWNER OF THE FIELD TODAY. HIS NAME IS BOAZ—AND HE WAS VERY KIND.
BOAZ? HE IS A RELATIVE OF MY HUSBAND'S FAMILY. GOD BLESS HIM FOR BEING KIND TO YOU.


ALL THROUGH THE HARVEST SEASON, RUTH GLEANS IN BOAZ'S FIELD AND TAKES CARE OF NAOMI. ONE EVENING ...
BOAZ HAS SHOWN THAT HE IS KIND TO YOU. AS A KINSMAN, HE HAS THE RIGHT TO MARRY YOU. THE HARVEST CELEBRATION IS TONIGHT. YOU SHOULD WEAR YOUR NICEST DRESS TO THE PARTY, AND THEN YOU SHOULD ASK HIM IF HE—AS YOUR RELATIVE AND REDEEMER—WOULD WANT TO MARRY AND TAKE CARE OF YOU.
BOAZ IS A GODLY MAN, AND I'LL DO WHAT YOU TELL ME.


RUTH DOES EVERYTHING EXACTLY AS NAOMI DESCRIBED. AND BOAZ NOTICES.
RUTH CAME!
NAOMI TOLD ME TO ASK YOU— SINCE YOU ARE A KINSMAN, WOULD YOU BE MY REDEEMER? WOULD YOU ... MARRY ME?
IS THERE NO ONE TO TAKE CARE OF YOU?
NO.
THEN I WILL.


THE NEWS OF RUTH AND BOAZ'S COMING MARRIAGE SPREADS RAPIDLY THROUGHOUT ALL BETHLEHEM. AT THE WEDDING THERE IS FEASTING, MUSIC, AND LAUGHTER.
ARE YOU HAPPY, MY DEAR?
HAPPIER THAN I EVER DREAMED I COULD BE. GOD HAS BEEN GOOD TO ME.
AFTER THE WEDDING, RUTH AND NAOMI MOVE INTO BOAZ'S BIG HOUSE. LATER, WHEN A SON IS BORN TO RUTH, NAOMI PROUDLY CARES FOR THE CHILD.
I THANK GOD FOR THE DAY YOU LEFT MOAB TO COME WITH ME TO BETHLEHEM. HE HAS TAKEN MY BITTER LIFE AND MADE IT SWEET AGAIN.
I THANK GOD TOO, NAOMI. HE HAS MADE GOOD COME OUT OF OUR SADNESS. HE HONORED US WITH A MAN WHO HONORS HIM. AND NOW I HAVE A BEAUTIFUL BABY.
MY SON IS NAMED OBED, WHICH MEANS "SERVANT." AND MY PRAYER IS THAT OBED WILL SERVE GOD AND HIS PEOPLE.
RUTH'S PRAYER COMES TRUE— FOR HER SON WILL BECOME THE GRANDFATHER OF DAVID, ISRAEL'S GREATEST KING, WHO WILL FREE HIS PEOPLE FROM THEIR ENEMIES.

Wake-Up Call

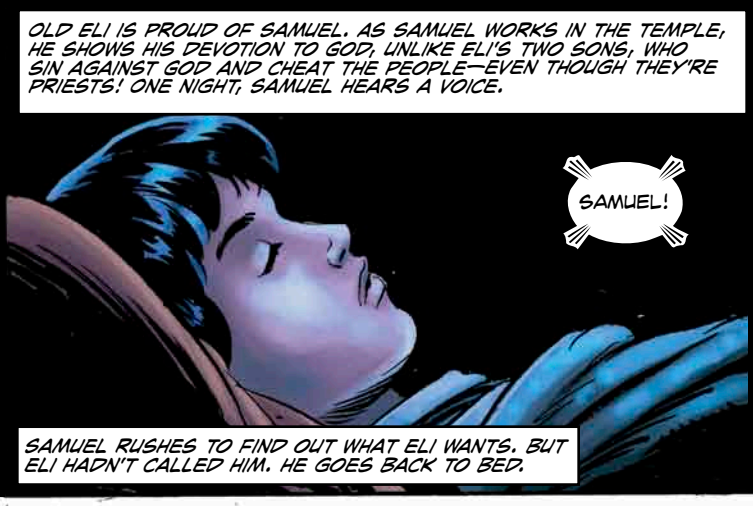
BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 1—3



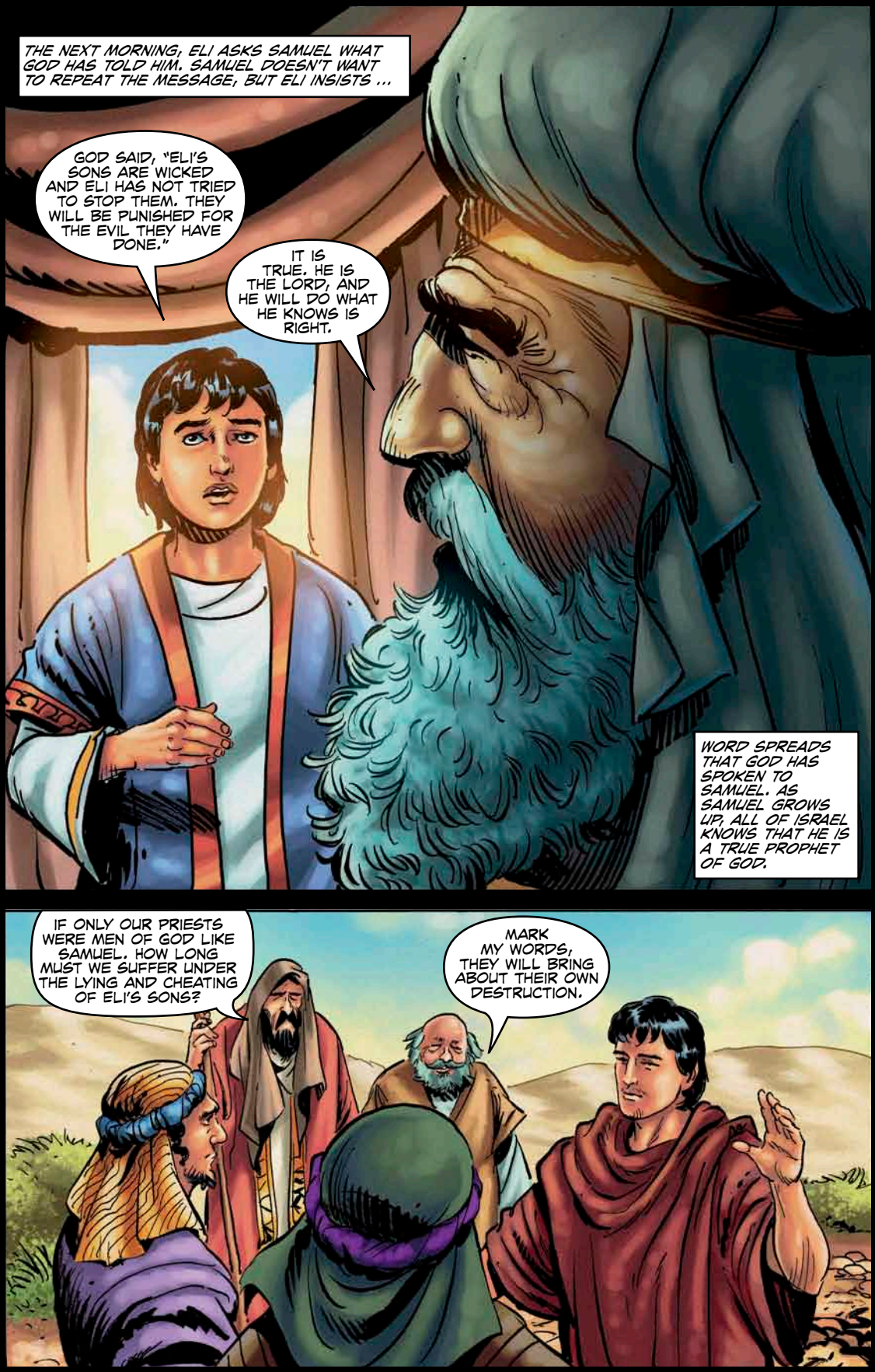

I AM SORRY FOR MY HASTY JUDGMENT. GO IN PEACE, HANNAH, AND MAY GOD GRANT YOU WHAT YOU'VE PRAYED FOR.
OH, LORD ALMIGHTY, IF YOU WILL HAVE PITY ON MY MISERY AND GIVE ME A SON, I WILL DEDICATE HIM TO YOU FOR ALL HIS DAYS.


GOD DOES ANSWER HANNAH'S PRAYER. WHEN HER LITTLE BOY IS OLD ENOUGH, SHE BRINGS HIM TO ELI.
WHEN I ASKED GOD FOR A SON, I PROMISED THAT HE WOULD SERVE THE LORD ALL HIS LIFE. SO I HAVE BROUGHT HIM HERE TO BE TRAINED IN GOD'S HOUSE. HIS NAME IS SAMUEL.
GOD BLESS YOU, HANNAH. I WILL TEACH YOUR SON TO BE A SERVANT OF THE LORD.


SAMUEL STAYS WITH ELI AND EAGERLY LEARNS HOW TO SERVE GOD. EACH YEAR WHEN HANNAH AND HER HUSBAND COME TO WORSHIP, SHE BRINGS SAMUEL A NEW COAT.
IT'S JUST LIKE A PRIEST'S ROBE. THANK YOU, MOTHER.

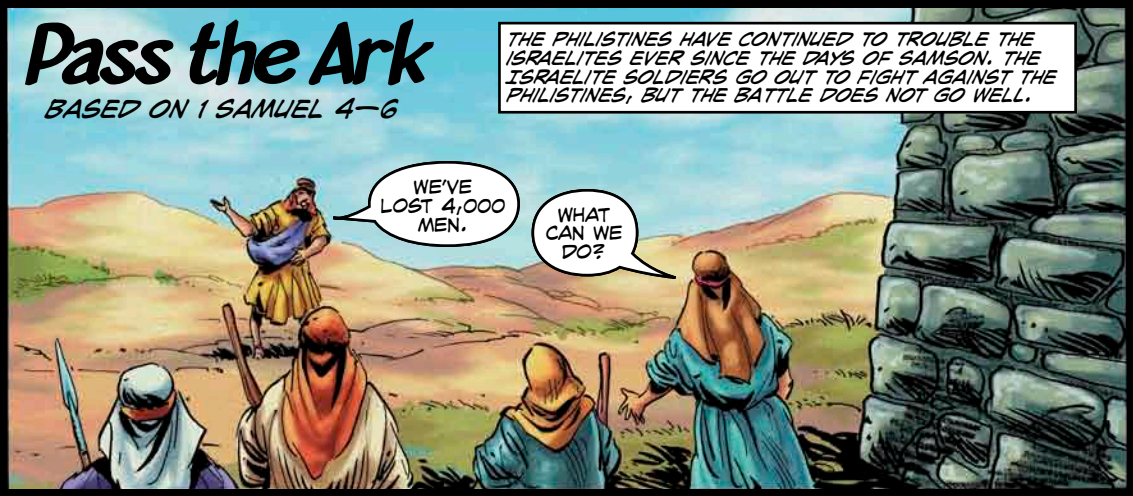

OLD ELI IS PROUD OF SAMUEL. AS SAMUEL WORKS IN THE TEMPLE, HE SHOWS HIS DEVOTION TO GOD, UNLIKE ELI'S TWO SONS, WHO SIN AGAINST GOD AND CHEAT THE PEOPLE—EVEN THOUGH THEY'RE PRIESTS! ONE NIGHT, SAMUEL HEARS A VOICE.
SAMUEL!
SAMUEL RUSHES TO FIND OUT WHAT ELI WANTS. BUT ELI HADN'T CALLED HIM. HE GOES BACK TO BED.


AGAIN, A VOICE CALLS HIM.
SAMUEL!
SAMUEL GOES RUNNING TO ELI'S ROOM AGAIN. EVENTUALLY, ELI REALIZES THAT GOD IS SPEAKING TO SAMUEL. HE INSTRUCTS SAMUEL TO ANSWER THE LORD, AND LISTEN TO WHATEVER MESSAGE GOD HAS FOR HIM.

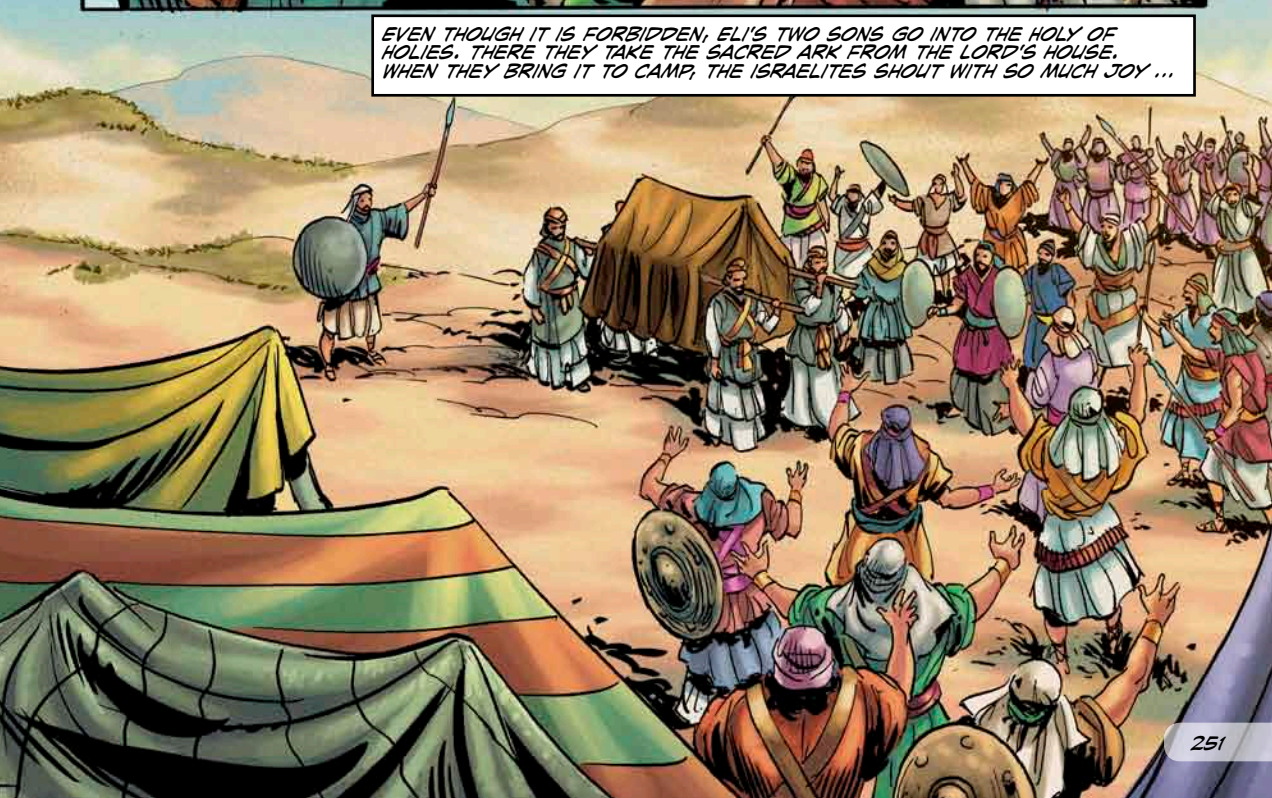

THE NEXT MORNING, ELI ASKS SAMUEL WHAT GOD HAS TOLD HIM. SAMUEL DOESN'T WANT TO REPEAT THE MESSAGE, BUT ELI INSISTS ...
GOD SAID, "ELI'S SONS ARE WICKED AND ELI HAS NOT TRIED TO STOP THEM. THEY WILL BE PUNISHED FOR THE EVIL THEY HAVE DONE."
IT IS TRUE. HE IS THE LORD, AND HE WILL DO WHAT HE KNOWS IS RIGHT.
WORD SPREADS THAT GOD HAS SPOKEN TO SAMUEL. AS SAMUEL GROWS UP, ALL OF ISRAEL KNOWS THAT HE IS A TRUE PROPHET OF GOD.
IF ONLY OUR PRIESTS WERE MEN OF GOD LIKE SAMUEL. HOW LONG MUST WE SUFFER UNDER THE LYING AND CHEATING OF ELI'S SONS?
MARK MY WORDS, THEY WILL BRING ABOUT THEIR OWN DESTRUCTION.

Pass the Ark

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 4–6








... THAT THE PHILISTINES IN THEIR CAMP CAN HEAR THEM.
THE WAY THE ISRAELITES ARE SHOUTING, YOU'D THINK THEY HAD WON THE BATTLE.
SEND SOMEONE TO FIND OUT WHAT'S GOING ON.
WE'RE IN TROUBLE! THEY'VE BROUGHT THAT ARK OF THEIR GOD INTO THEIR CAMP.
YOU MEAN, THE SAME GOD WHO SENT SO MANY PLAGUES ON THE EGYPTIANS THAT THEY HAD TO FREE THE ISRAELITES? HOW CAN WE FIGHT THAT KIND OF POWER?
IF WE DON'T FIGHT, WE'LL BE SLAVES TO THE ISRAELITES WHO HAVE BEEN *OUR* SLAVES! NOW IS THE TIME TO BE MEN! COME, WE MUST STRIKE FIRST BEFORE THEIR GOD CAN STRIKE US.


THE PHILISTINES ATTACK! BUT THE ISRAELITES, BELIEVING IN THE POWER OF THE ARK, COUNTERATTACK WITH SUDDEN FURY.
CAPTURE THE ARK, AND THEY'LL GIVE UP!
THE PHILISTINES CAPTURE THE ARK, AND THE ISRAELITES FLEE IN TERROR. THEIR FAITH IN GOD HAD BECOME A SUPERSTITIOUS BELIEF IN THE ARK. A MESSENGER TAKES THE NEWS TO ELI.
THE BATTLE IS LOST! YOUR SONS ARE DEAD! AND THE PHILISTINES HAVE CAPTURED THE ARK.
THE ARK IS CAPTURED?
AT THE NEWS, ELI FALLS AND BREAKS HIS NECK. MEANWHILE, THE PHILISTINES TRIUMPHANTLY CARRY THE ARK HOME TO THE CITY OF ASHDOD AND PLACE IT IN THE TEMPLE OF THEIR GOD, DAGON.
LET THIS BE A SIGN THAT OUR GOD DAGON HAS CONQUERED THE GOD OF ISRAEL.
BUT IN THE MORNING ...


LOOK! OUR GREAT GOD DAGON LIES BROKEN BEFORE THE ARK OF THE ISRAELITES!
NOT ONLY IS THEIR IDOL DESTROYED, BUT A PLAGUE BREAKS OUT IN ASHDOD. SO THE PHILISTINES CARRY THE ARK FROM ONE CITY TO ANOTHER. IN EACH CITY A PLAGUE BREAKS OUT.
OUR FIELDS ARE OVERRUN WITH MICE. I TELL YOU, A CURSE HAS BEEN PUT ON OUR CITIES.
NOT A SINGLE FAMILY HAS ESCAPED THIS MYSTERY DISEASE.
THE PHILISTINES SOON REALIZE THAT THEIR TROUBLES BEGAN WHEN THEY CAPTURED THE ARK OF ISRAEL. FINALLY, THEY RETURN THE ARK. BUT NOW ISRAEL IS WORSHIPPING IDOLS. SOME MEN TAKE THE ARK TO A HOUSE IN KIRIATH JEARIM, WHERE IT LIES FORGOTTEN FOR MANY YEARS ...

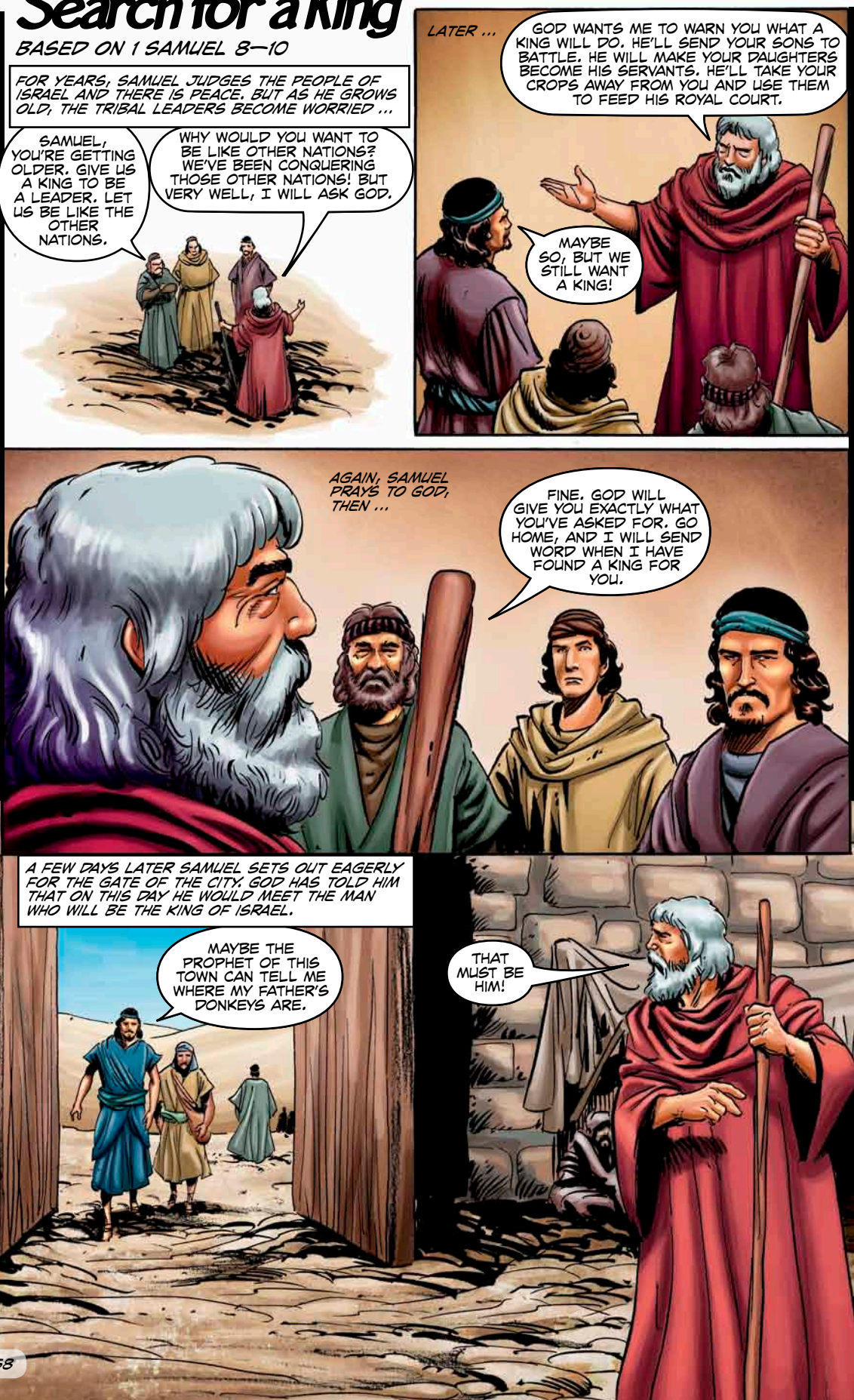

A Miracle at Mizpah
BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 7
YOUNG SAMUEL GROWS UP TO BE A GODLY MAN. AND AFTER YEARS OF STRUGGLE UNDER THE PHILISTINES, THE ISRAELITES ARE FINALLY READY TO LISTEN WHEN SAMUEL SPEAKS ...
RETURN TO THE LORD! WORSHIP HIM WITH ALL YOUR HEARTS, AND GOD WILL DELIVER YOU FROM THE PHILISTINES.
SAMUEL IS RIGHT! LET'S THROW AWAY OUR IDOLS AND WORSHIP GOD.
LET'S ALL GO TO THE CITY OF MIZPAH, WHERE WE CAN REPENT AND PRAY TOGETHER!
EAGERLY, THE PEOPLE FOLLOW THIS MAN WHO SPEAKS BOLDLY FOR GOD. BY THE THOUSANDS THEY SET OUT ...
BUT THE PHILISTINES DISCOVER THE GREAT MARCH TO MIZPAH.
IF THOUSANDS OF ISRAELITES ARE MASSING AT MIZPAH, IT CAN MEAN ONLY ONE THING—THEY PLAN TO ATTACK US.
WE'LL STRIKE BEFORE THEY DO, AND THIS TIME WE'LL CRUSH THEM SO BADLY THEY'LL NEVER FIGHT AGAIN.


MEANTIME, AT MIZPAH, THE ISRAELITES ASSEMBLE BEFORE AN ALTAR TO GOD.
FORGIVE YOUR PEOPLE, LORD, AND HELP THEM. THEY HAVE TORN DOWN THE IDOLS AND REPENTED FOR TURNING AWAY FROM YOU.
SUDDENLY A LOUD SHOUT RINGS THROUGH THE CAMP ...
HELP! THE PHILISTINES ARE COMING!
ASK GOD TO SAVE US, SAMUEL—OR WE WILL ALL BE KILLED!

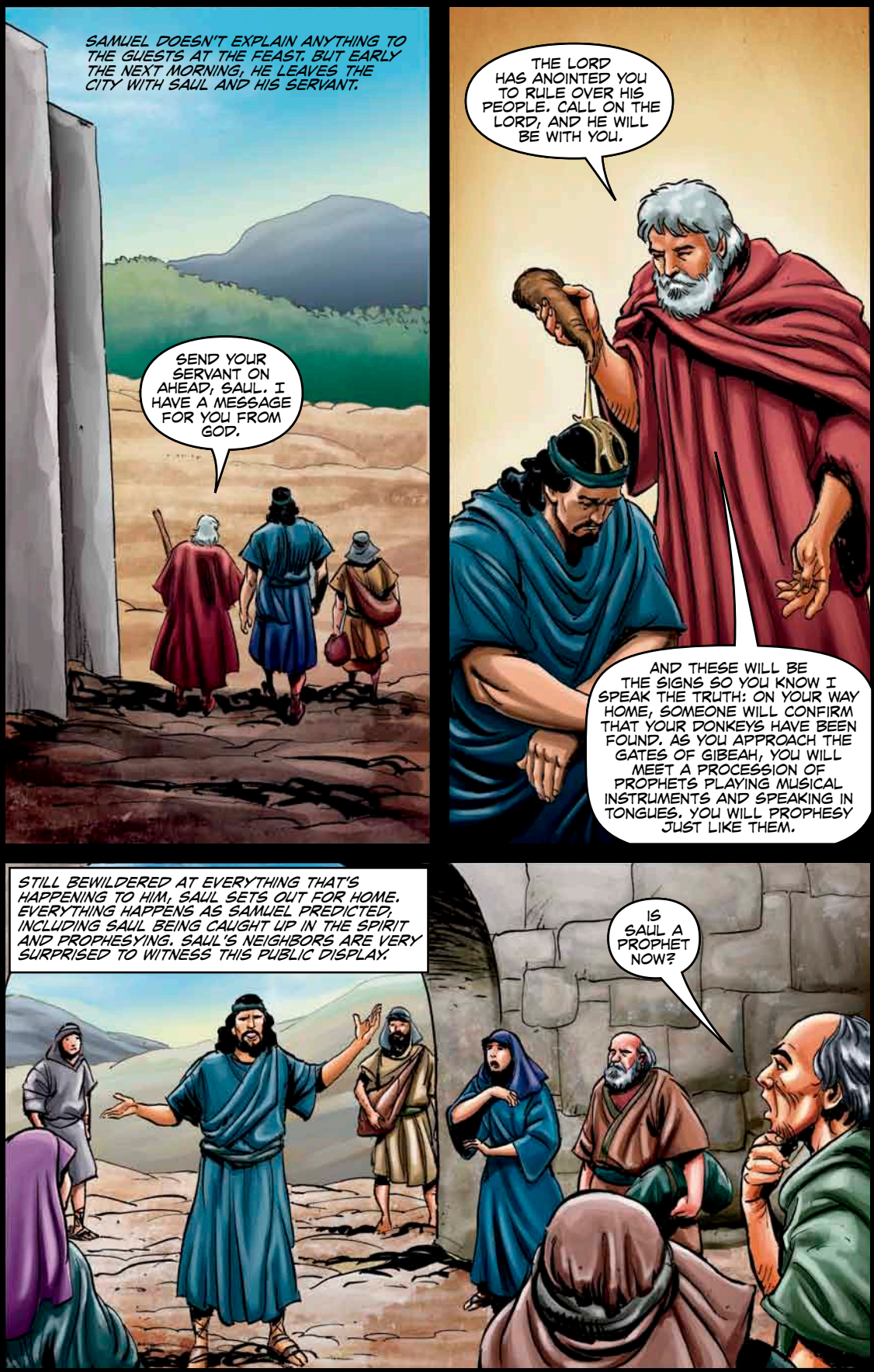

THE PHILISTINE ARMY PREPARES FOR A RUSH ATTACK ON THE ISRAELITES AT MIZPAH. ON THE HILLTOP, SAMUEL OFFERS A SACRIFICE AND PRAYS FOR GOD'S HELP.
THIS TIME WE'LL TEACH THEM A LESSON THEY WON'T FORGET.
BUT WHEN THE PHILISTINES ARE WITHIN BATTLE RANGE, A SUDDEN STORM BREAKS ...
WE CAN FIGHT THE ISRAELITES, BUT WE CAN'T FIGHT THE GOD OF THUNDER AND LIGHTNING.
GOD HAS ANSWERED OUR PRAYER!
LET'S GO AFTER THEM.
THE PHILISTINE DEFEAT IS A TURNING POINT IN ISRAEL'S HISTORY. NEVER AGAIN WHILE SAMUEL IS ISRAEL'S LEADER DO THE PHILISTINES INVADE ISRAEL. AS A REMINDER OF GOD'S HELP, SAMUEL PUTS UP A STONE MONUMENT. HE CALLS IT EBENEZER, WHICH MEANS "STONE OF HELP."

Search for a King

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 8–10




EXCUSE ME, I'M LOOKING FOR—
—YES, YES. YOUR DONKEYS HAVE ALREADY BEEN FOUND AND RETURNED TO YOUR FATHER. BUT WE HAVE BIGGER THINGS TO TALK ABOUT. COME WITH ME TO WORSHIP THE LORD, AND TOMORROW I WILL TELL YOU WHAT GREAT THINGS ARE IN STORE FOR YOU.
GREAT THINGS FOR ME? WHAT DOES HE MEAN? I'M ONLY THE SON OF KISH, SON OF MATRI, DESCENDED FROM BENJAMIN, THE SMALLEST TRIBE OF ISRAEL. MY FAMILY AND I ARE NOT IMPORTANT.
SAUL, A SIMPLE YOUNG FARMER, IS STUNNED WHEN SAMUEL TELLS HIM THAT GOD HAS GREAT THINGS PLANNED FOR HIM. THEY WORSHIP GOD TOGETHER. THEN SAMUEL GIVES SAUL THE SEAT OF HONOR AT A SPECIAL FEAST.
SAMUEL TOLD US TWO DAYS AGO TO COOK THIS PORTION SPECIAL, JUST FOR YOU.
HOW DID HE EVEN KNOW I WAS COMING?


SAMUEL DOESN'T EXPLAIN ANYTHING TO THE GUESTS AT THE FEAST. BUT EARLY THE NEXT MORNING, HE LEAVES THE CITY WITH SAUL AND HIS SERVANT.
SEND YOUR SERVANT ON AHEAD, SAUL. I HAVE A MESSAGE FOR YOU FROM GOD.
THE LORD HAS ANOINTED YOU TO RULE OVER HIS PEOPLE. CALL ON THE LORD, AND HE WILL BE WITH YOU.
AND THESE WILL BE THE SIGNS SO YOU KNOW I SPEAK THE TRUTH: ON YOUR WAY HOME, SOMEONE WILL CONFIRM THAT YOUR DONKEYS HAVE BEEN FOUND. AS YOU APPROACH THE GATES OF GIBEAH, YOU WILL MEET A PROCESSION OF PROPHETS PLAYING MUSICAL INSTRUMENTS AND SPEAKING IN TONGUES. YOU WILL PROPHESY JUST LIKE THEM.
STILL BEWILDERED AT EVERYTHING THAT'S HAPPENING TO HIM, SAUL SETS OUT FOR HOME. EVERYTHING HAPPENS AS SAMUEL PREDICTED, INCLUDING SAUL BEING CAUGHT UP IN THE SPIRIT AND PROPHESYING. SAUL'S NEIGHBORS ARE VERY SURPRISED TO WITNESS THIS PUBLIC DISPLAY.
IS SAUL A PROPHET NOW?

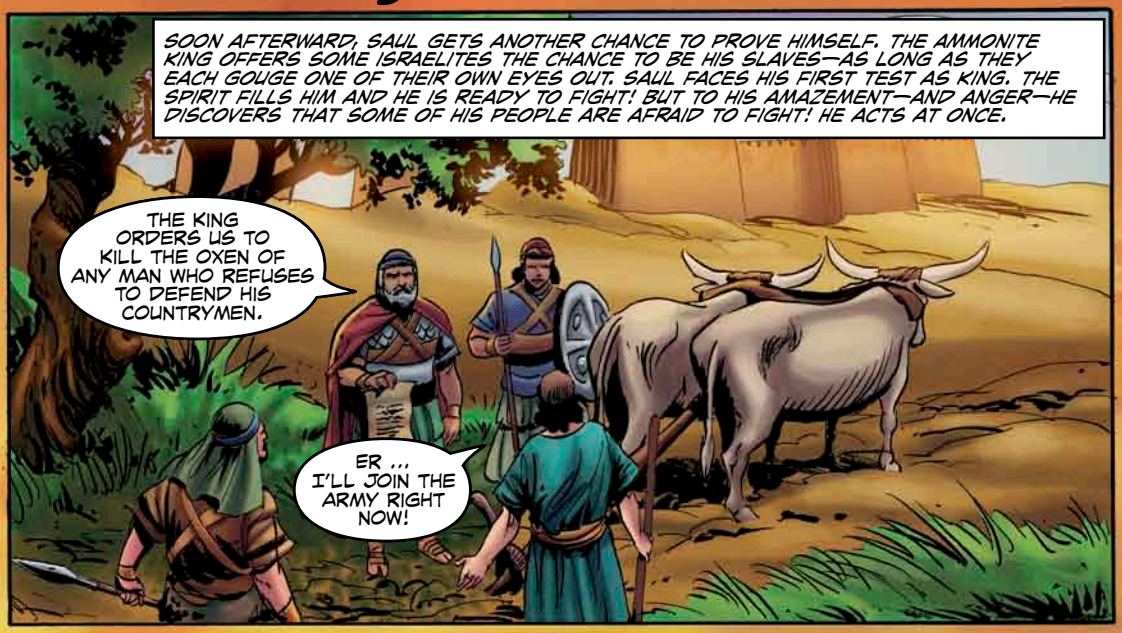

A FEW DAYS LATER, SAMUEL CALLS ALL THE TRIBES TOGETHER.
TODAY, GOD WILL REVEAL TO YOU YOUR KING!
WHO IS HE?


THE PEOPLE CAST LOTS, KNOWING THAT GOD'S SPIRIT WILL DECIDE THE OUTCOME. SLOWLY BUT SURELY, THE CHOICE FOR THEIR NEW KING GETS NARROWED DOWN.
OUR KING WILL COME FROM THE TRIBE OF BENJAMIN ...
... AND THE CLAN OF MATRI ...
... AND THE FAMILY OF KISH ...


OUT OF ALL THE PEOPLE AND TRIBES, SAUL'S NAME IS CHOSEN, JUST AS GOD FORETOLD. BUT SAUL IS NOWHERE TO BE FOUND. SAMUEL TELLS THE PEOPLE WHERE TO SEARCH, AND SAUL IS SOON FOUND—HIDING AMONG THE LUGGAGE!
WHAT ARE YOU DOING HIDING IN THE BAGS AND BASKETS??
I WAS SCARED TO BE CHOSEN KING.
HIDING IN THE LUGGAGE? NOT A GREAT START FOR A NEW KING!

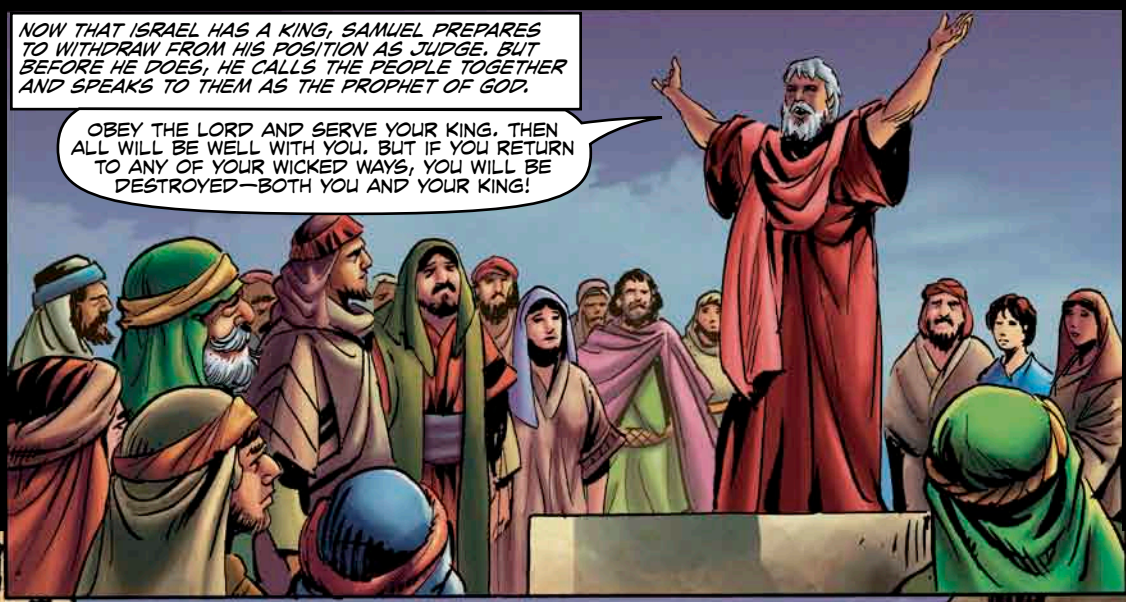
Saul's Bravery

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 11—12






PROUD OF THEIR VICTORY, THE ISRAELITES SHOUT THEIR PRAISES TO SAUL.
SURE, THEY'RE ALL FOR YOU TODAY. BUT WHAT ABOUT THE MEN WHO DIDN'T WANT YOU TO BE KING? THEY SHOULD BE KILLED.
NO! NO MAN WILL BE PUT TO DEATH FOR THAT.

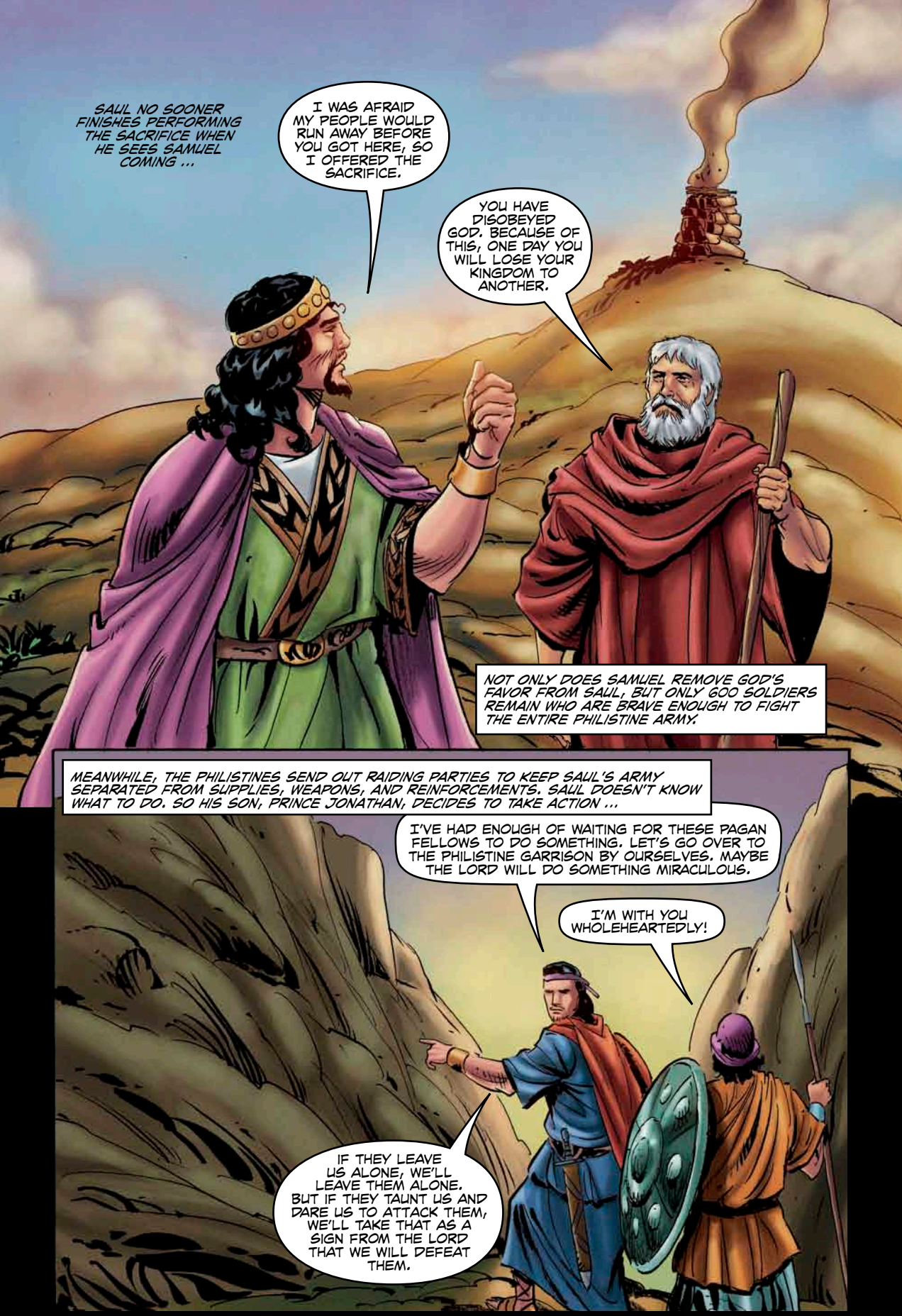

NOW THAT ISRAEL HAS A KING, SAMUEL PREPARES TO WITHDRAW FROM HIS POSITION AS JUDGE. BUT BEFORE HE DOES, HE CALLS THE PEOPLE TOGETHER AND SPEAKS TO THEM AS THE PROPHET OF GOD.
OBEY THE LORD AND SERVE YOUR KING. THEN ALL WILL BE WELL WITH YOU. BUT IF YOU RETURN TO ANY OF YOUR WICKED WAYS, YOU WILL BE DESTROYED—BOTH YOU AND YOUR KING!


SPURRED ON BY HIS VICTORY OVER THE AMMONITES, SAUL FORMS A STANDING ARMY AND PREPARES TO WIN HIS PEOPLE'S FREEDOM FROM THE PHILISTINES. HIS SON JONATHAN STARTS BY SUCCESSFULLY CONQUERING A PHILISTINE GARRISON—AND AGAIN ISRAEL CHEERS.

Honeycomb Argument

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 13—14




SAUL NO SOONER FINISHES PERFORMING THE SACRIFICE WHEN HE SEES SAMUEL COMING ...
I WAS AFRAID MY PEOPLE WOULD RUN AWAY BEFORE YOU GOT HERE, SO I OFFERED THE SACRIFICE.
YOU HAVE DISOBEYED GOD. BECAUSE OF THIS, ONE DAY YOU WILL LOSE YOUR KINGDOM TO ANOTHER.
NOT ONLY DOES SAMUEL REMOVE GOD'S FAVOR FROM SAUL, BUT ONLY 600 SOLDIERS REMAIN WHO ARE BRAVE ENOUGH TO FIGHT THE ENTIRE PHILISTINE ARMY.
MEANWHILE, THE PHILISTINES SEND OUT RAIDING PARTIES TO KEEP SAUL'S ARMY SEPARATED FROM SUPPLIES, WEAPONS, AND REINFORCEMENTS. SAUL DOESN'T KNOW WHAT TO DO. SO HIS SON, PRINCE JONATHAN, DECIDES TO TAKE ACTION ...
I'VE HAD ENOUGH OF WAITING FOR THESE PAGAN FELLOWS TO DO SOMETHING. LET'S GO OVER TO THE PHILISTINE GARRISON BY OURSELVES. MAYBE THE LORD WILL DO SOMETHING MIRACULOUS.
I'M WITH YOU WHOLEHEARTEDLY!
IF THEY LEAVE US ALONE, WE'LL LEAVE THEM ALONE. BUT IF THEY TAUNT US AND DARE US TO ATTACK THEM, WE'LL TAKE THAT AS A SIGN FROM THE LORD THAT WE WILL DEFEAT THEM.


SECRETLY, JONATHAN AND HIS ARMOR-BEARER LEAVE CAMP. WHEN THEY REACH THE FOOT OF THE CLIFF THAT LEADS TO THE PHILISTINE GARRISON, THE ENEMY DARES THEM TO COME UP AND FIGHT. BOLDLY, JONATHAN AND HIS FRIEND SCALE THE CLIFF ...
FOLLOW ME. SINCE THE LORD IS WITH US, WE DON'T NEED A LOT OF SOLDIERS.
AT THE TOP OF THE CLIFF, THEY ATTACK WITH SUCH DARING THAT THE PHILISTINES FLEE IN PANIC. IN THEIR CONFUSION, THE PHILISTINES EVEN ATTACK ONE ANOTHER.
FROM HIS CAMP, SAUL SEES THE PHILISTINES RETREATING. WHEN HE DISCOVERS THAT JONATHAN IS MISSING, HE KNOWS WHO MUST BE RESPONSIBLE FOR THIS MIRACLE. SAUL'S SOLDIERS RUN TO CATCH UP TO JONATHAN AND JOIN IN THE ATTACK.

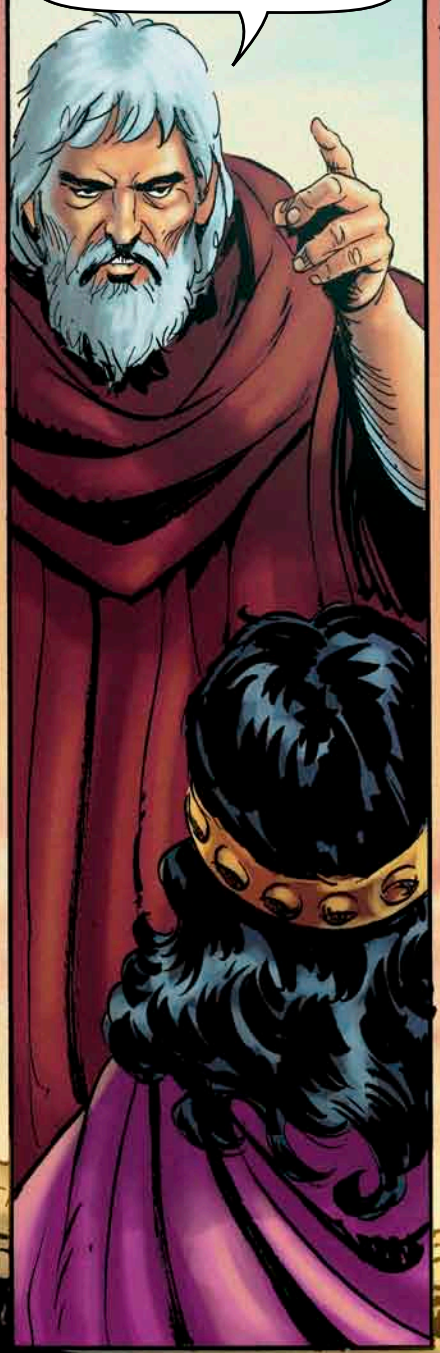

JONATHAN'S PURSUIT OF THE FLEEING PHILISTINES TAKES HIM THROUGH THE WOODS. THERE HE SEES HONEY OOZING OUT OF A FALLEN BEEHIVE.
PRAISE THE LORD, I HAVEN'T EATEN ALL DAY.
HE GRABS A HONEYCOMB. AS SOON AS HE'S EATEN IT, HE GETS ALL OF HIS ENERGY BACK.
COME ON! LET'S TEACH THESE PAGAN DOGS A LESSON!
BUT THE SOLDIERS DON'T FOLLOW HIM.
WHY IS EVERYONE SO TIRED? GOD HAS DELIVERED THESE PHILISTINES INTO OUR HANDS, IF WE CAN JUST KEEP CHASING THEM!
WHILE YOU WERE GONE, YOUR FATHER SWORE AN OATH THAT NO SOLDIER COULD EAT ANYTHING UNTIL NIGHTFALL.
THE HUNGRY SOLDIERS GIVE UP THEIR PURSUIT AND GO BACK TO KING SAUL'S CAMP. SAUL IS FURIOUS WHEN HE FINDS OUT THAT JONATHAN ATE SOME FOOD.
YOU DISHONORED MY OATH! SO HELP ME GOD, I WILL HAVE YOU EXECUTED FOR THIS!
YOU WILL KILL ME BECAUSE I DIDN'T KNOW ABOUT YOUR FOOLISH OATH?? IF OUR SOLDIERS HAD BEEN ALLOWED TO EAT, WE COULD HAVE CONQUERED ALL THE PHILISTINES ON THIS DAY. YOUR STUPID DECISION COST US THE VICTORY THAT GOD TRIED TO GIVE US!
YOUR SON IS A HERO! HE DELIVERED US FROM THE PHILISTINES! GOD HAS SHOWN HIM FAVOR; WE WILL NOT LET HIM BE KILLED!
SAUL BACKS DOWN, BUT THIS IS NOT THE LAST TIME HIS TEMPER WILL GET HIM IN TROUBLE ...

The Final Strike

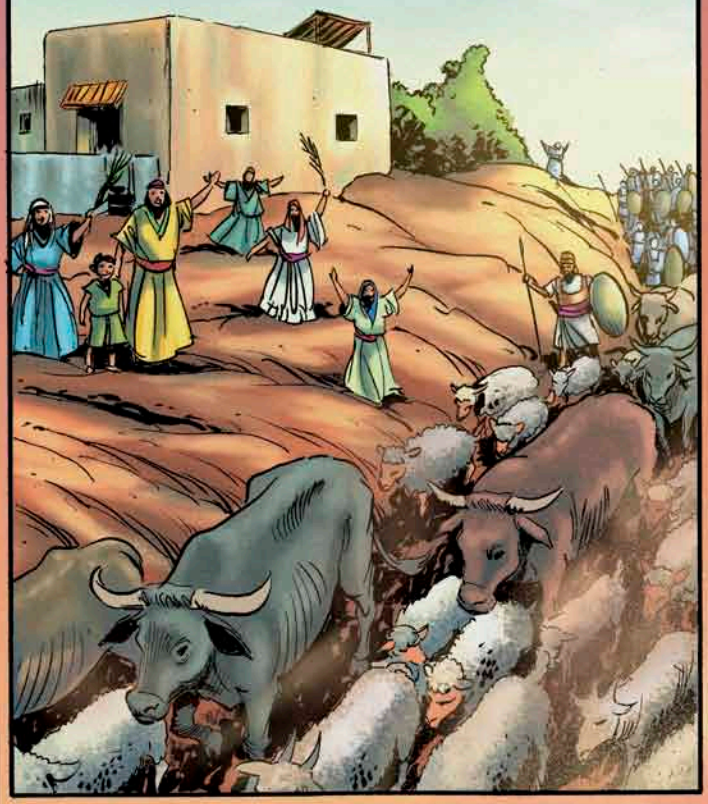
BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 15

EVEN THOUGH THE PHILISTINES ARE NOT COMPLETELY DEFEATED, THEY STOP BOTHERING ISRAEL FOR A WHILE. BUT OTHER ENEMIES CONTINUE TO TROUBLE THE PEOPLE. ONE DAY SAMUEL CALLS SAUL TO HIM ...

THE LORD WANTS YOU TO DESTROY THE AMALEKITES. THEY HAVE BEEN ENEMIES OF ISRAEL EVER SINCE OUR PEOPLE LEFT EGYPT. DESTROY EVERYTHING! DON'T BRING ANYTHING HOME WITH YOU, FOR THIS IS NOT A WAR TO GET RICH.



SAUL ATTACKS THE AMALEKITES AND DRIVES THEM BACK TOWARD EGYPT. BUT INSTEAD OF KILLING EVERYTHING, HE BRINGS THE BEST OF THE SHEEP AND OXEN HOME WITH HIM.



AT GILGAL, SAUL COMES FACE-TO-FACE WITH SAMUEL ...

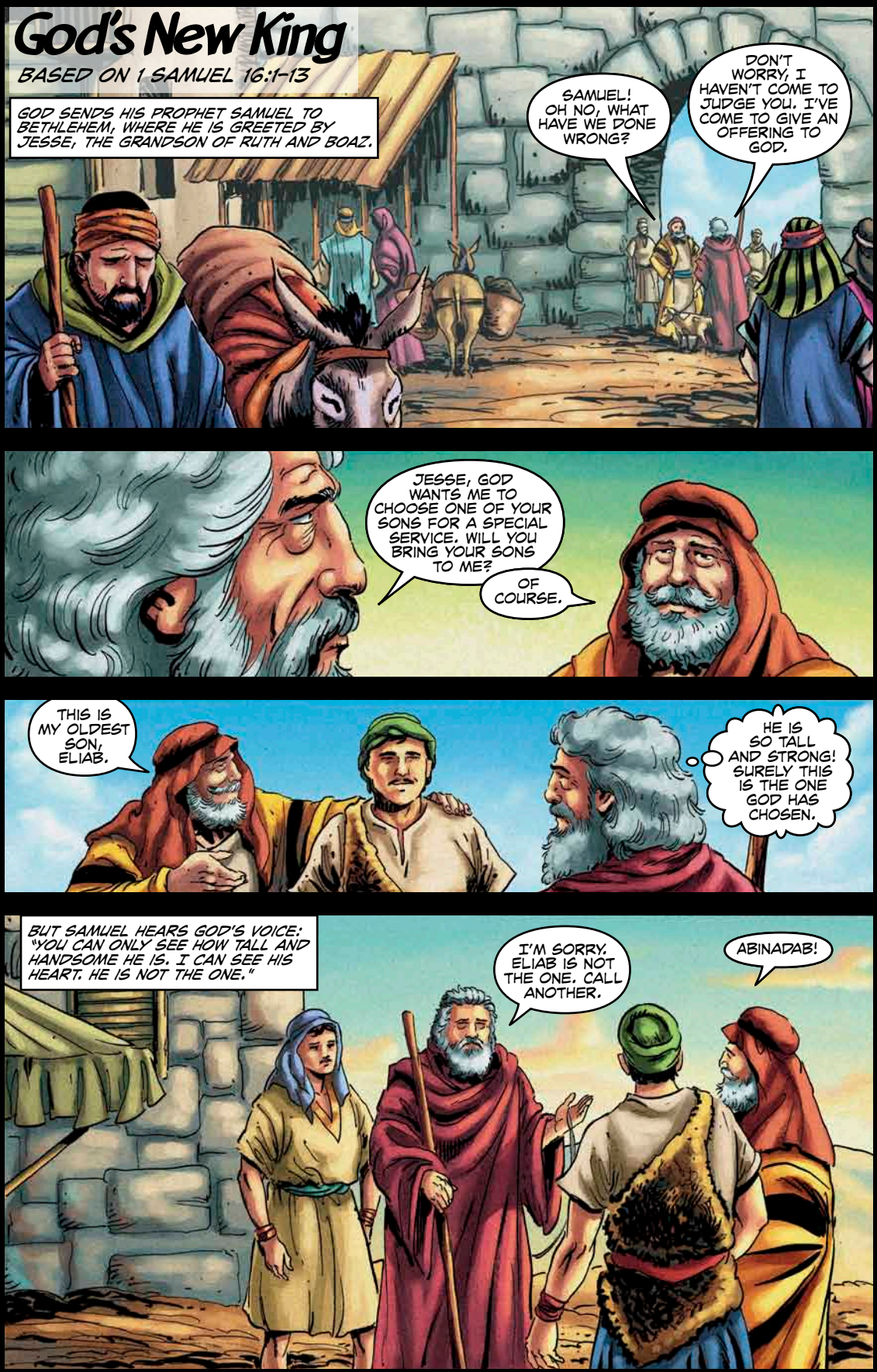
I HAVE OBEYED GOD'S COMMAND AND DESTROYED THE AMALEKITES AND EVERYTHING THEY POSSESS.




REALLY? THEN WHY DO I HEAR THE NOISE OF SHEEP AND OXEN?
I THOUGHT I'D SAVE SOME OF THE BEST ANIMALS TO SACRIFICE TO GOD.
OBEDIENCE IS BETTER THAN SACRIFICE. THIS IS THE SECOND TIME YOU HAVE DISOBEYED GOD. YOU'VE REJECTED THE LORD; NOW HE WILL REJECT YOU AS KING.
NO! MY PEOPLE— I ...
YOU MAY TEAR MY ROBE, BUT GOD WILL TEAR HIS KINGDOM AWAY FROM YOU—AND GIVE IT TO A BETTER MAN!
SAUL TRIES TO STOP SAMUEL FROM LEAVING AND ACCIDENTALLY TEARS HIS CLOAK.
AT FIRST SAUL TRIES TO LAY BLAME ON HIS PEOPLE, BUT FINALLY HE ADMITS HE HAS SINNED AGAINST GOD. SAMUEL PRAYS WITH SAUL AND THEN GOES HOME, NEVER TO VISIT THE KING AGAIN.

God's New King

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 16:1-13



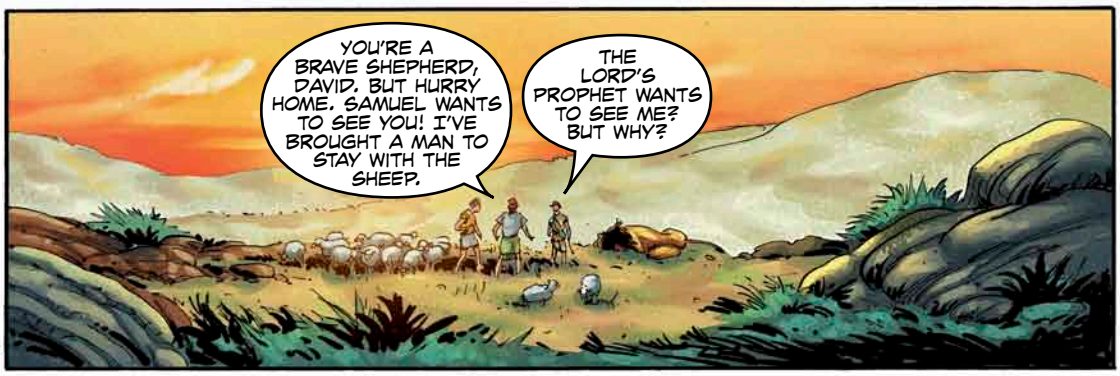




JESSE'S SON FINDS HIS BROTHER IN THE FIELDS OUTSIDE BETHLEHEM.




JUST LIKE HIS GREAT-GRANDPARENTS, DAVID IS HONORABLE, FAITHFUL, AND BRAVE. HIS KEEN EARS HEAR A SWISH IN THE TALL GRASS. HE WHIRLS ...
A LION!
GRRRR
ROAR
WHISH
DAVID! THE LION— YOU KILLED IT!
I ALSO HAD TO KILL A BEAR A FEW DAYS AGO. NOTHING'S GOING TO HURT MY FATHER'S SHEEP IF I CAN HELP IT.


YOU'RE A BRAVE SHEPHERD, DAVID. BUT HURRY HOME. SAMUEL WANTS TO SEE YOU! I'VE BROUGHT A MAN TO STAY WITH THE SHEEP.
THE LORD'S PROPHET WANTS TO SEE ME? BUT WHY?


ON THE HIKE BACK TO THE CITY, DAVID CONTINUES TO WONDER. BUT WHEN SAMUEL SEES THE YOUNG SHEPHERD BOY, HE HEARS GOD SAY, "THIS IS MY CHOSEN ONE."


IN FRONT OF JESSE AND HIS SONS, SAMUEL BLESSES DAVID AND ANOINTS HIS HEAD WITH OIL.
THE LORD BLESS YOU, FOR YOU WILL BE THE NEXT KING OF ISRAEL.

A Psalming Influence

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 16:14-23; PSALM 23




GOD USES DAVID'S MUSICAL TALENT TO INTRODUCE HIM TO THE ROYAL COURT—THE FIRST STEP TOWARD MAKING HIM KING OF ISRAEL ONE DAY. HERE DAVID CAN LEARN ABOUT KINGSHIP AND GOVERNMENT. HE CAN ALSO WITNESS WHAT LIFE IS LIKE FOR KING SAUL, WHO DOESN'T RELY ON THE LORD.
THE KING IS VERY ILL TODAY, SO HE MAY BE DANGEROUS. DON'T TAKE YOUR EYES OFF OF HIM FOR A SECOND.
QUIETLY, DAVID ENTERS THE KING'S ROOM AND BEGINS TO PLAY. SAUL STARES AT HIM WILDLY, BUT DAVID CONTINUES TO PLAY AND SING OF HIS FAITH IN GOD.
AT LAST KING SAUL RELAXES AND FALLS ASLEEP. AFTER THAT, DAVID IS OFTEN CALLED TO THE PALACE. HIS MUSIC QUIETS SAUL'S TORTURED MIND, AND EVENTUALLY THE KING SEEMS WELL AGAIN—FOR A TIME.

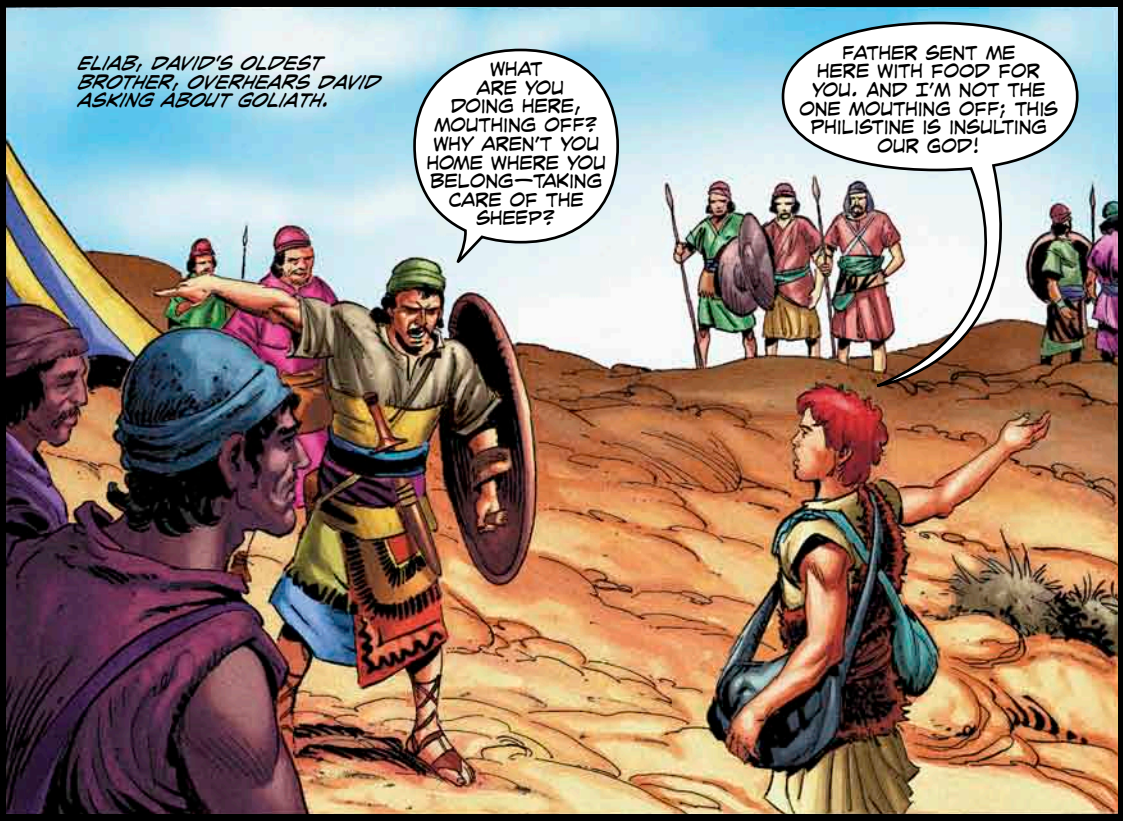
A Giant Challenge

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 17

A FEW YEARS LATER, THE PHILISTINES COLLECT THEIR FORCES FOR AN ATTACK AGAINST ISRAEL. SAUL MASSES HIS ARMY AGAINST THEM, AND DAVID'S THREE OLDEST BROTHERS JOIN THE KING'S FORCES.




WHAT'S GOING ON? LISTEN TO THAT GIANT!
WHY DO YOU BOTHER LINING UP FOR BATTLE? JUST SEND OUT A MAN WHO DARES TO FIGHT ME. IF HE KILLS ME, THEN THE PHILISTINES WILL ALL PUT DOWN THEIR WEAPONS AND BE YOUR SERVANTS.
BUT IF I KILL HIM, YOU WILL BE *OUR* SERVANTS.
WHO IS THIS UNCLEAN PHILISTINE THAT THINKS HE CAN DEFY THE ARMY OF GOD?
THAT'S GOLIATH. THE KING HAS SAID THAT WHOEVER DEFEATS HIM WILL RECEIVE GREAT WEALTH, SAUL'S OWN DAUGHTER, AND—BEST OF ALL—HE'LL NEVER HAVE TO PAY TAXES AGAIN! BUT NO MAN DARES TO FACE GOLIATH.


ELIAB, DAVID'S OLDEST BROTHER, OVERHEARS DAVID ASKING ABOUT GOLIATH.
WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE, MOUTHING OFF? WHY AREN'T YOU HOME WHERE YOU BELONG—TAKING CARE OF THE SHEEP?
FATHER SENT ME HERE WITH FOOD FOR YOU. AND I'M NOT THE ONE MOUTHING OFF; THIS PHILISTINE IS INSULTING OUR GOD!

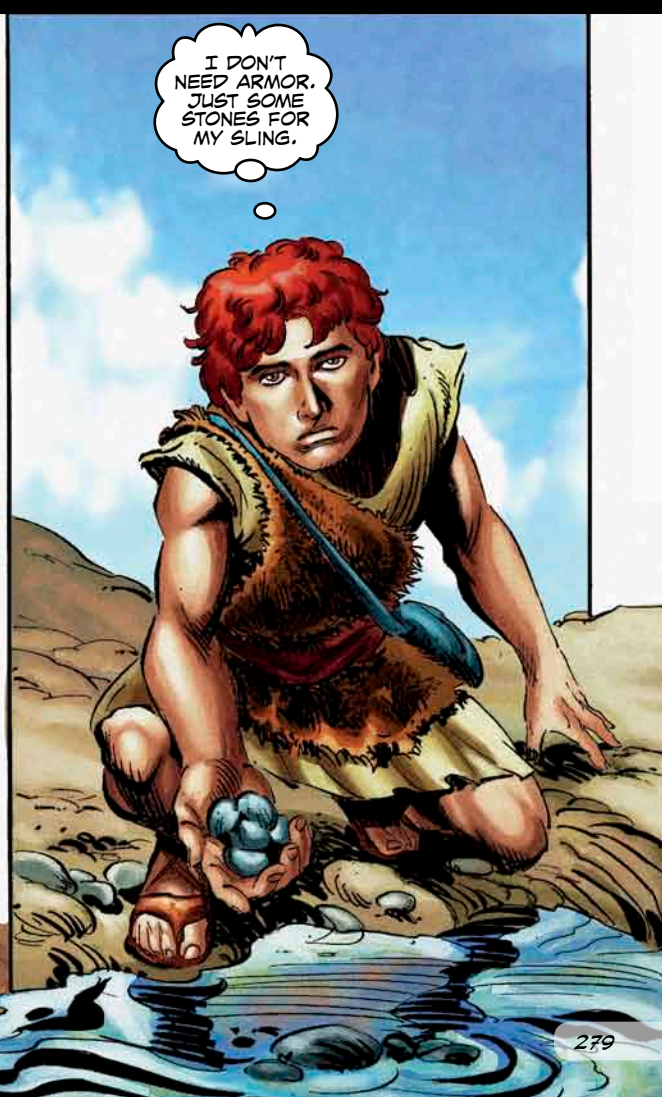

EVER SINCE THE PROPHET SAMUEL CHOSE DAVID INSTEAD OF HIM, ELIAB HAS BEEN FILLED WITH JEALOUSY. NOW HIS SHAME BURSTS INTO THE OPEN.
YOU'RE JUST A SPOILED KID WHO WANTS TO WATCH A BATTLE FOR YOUR OWN FUN.
NO, I JUST HATE TO SEE OUR GOD DISRESPECTED. I'LL FIGHT THE GIANT.

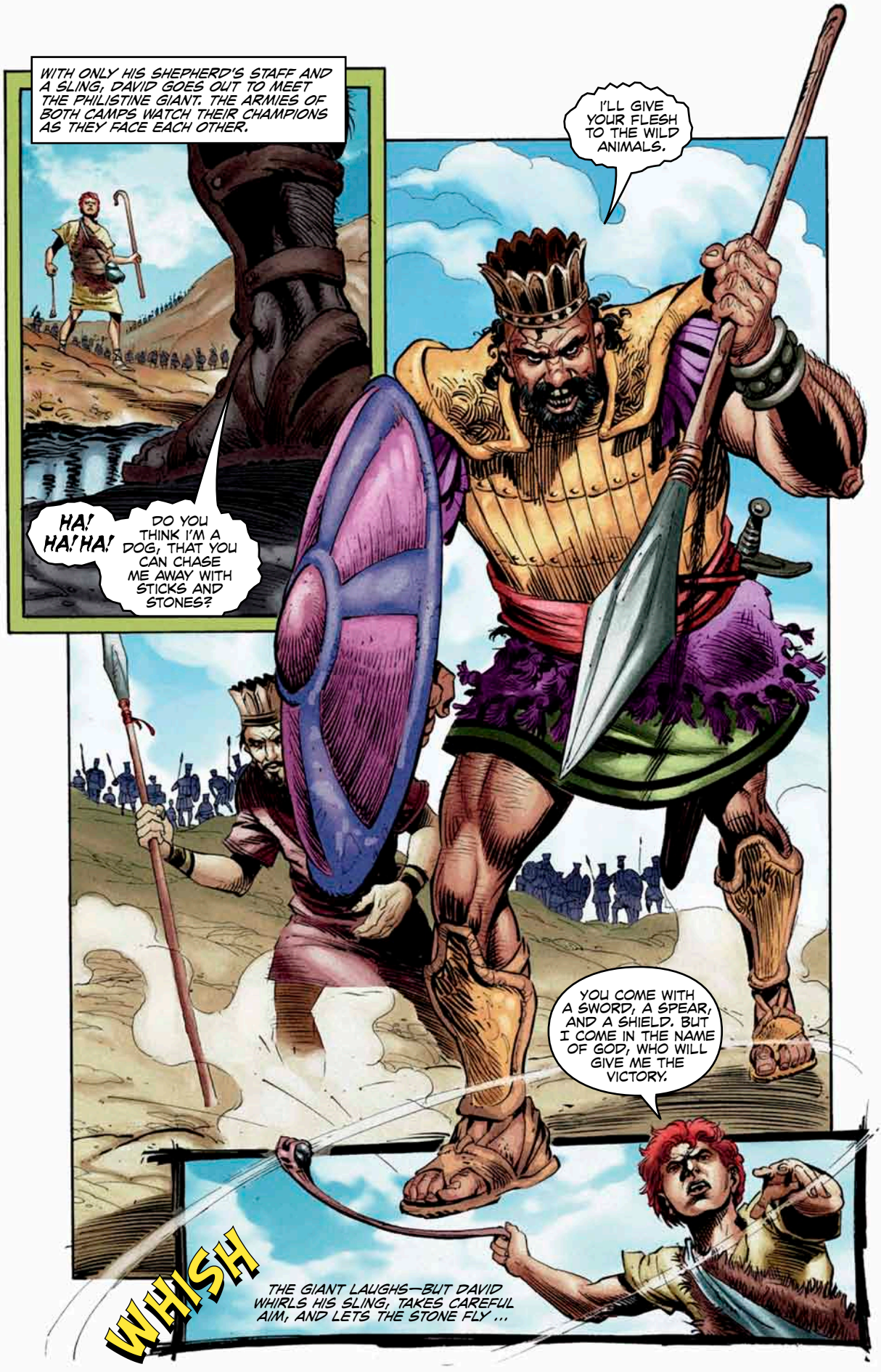

DAVID'S WORDS SPREAD THROUGH THE CAMP.
O KING, THERE IS ONE PERSON WHO WILL FIGHT, BUT ...
BRING HIM HERE AT ONCE!


DAVID ENTERS SAUL'S TENT—BUT SAUL DOES NOT RECOGNIZE THIS YOUNG SHEPHERD AS THE SAME BOY WHO USED TO PLAY FOR HIM.
AN UNTRAINED TEENAGER! YOU CAN'T FIGHT A GIANT! HE'S AN ELITE WARRIOR.


I AM A SHEPHERD. I HAVE KILLED BEARS AND LIONS TO PROTECT MY SHEEP. THE LORD IS OUR SHEPHERD, SO GOD WILL HELP ME KILL THIS PHILISTINE TO PROTECT OUR PEOPLE.
SPOKEN WITH COURAGE AND FAITH. GO, AND THE LORD BE WITH YOU. YOU MAY EVEN WEAR MY OWN ARMOR TO PROTECT YOU FROM THIS MONSTER.


I CAN'T WEAR THIS—I'M NOT USED TO FIGHTING IN ARMOR. BESIDES, MY PLAN IS NOT TO DEFEND MYSELF, BUT TO ATTACK.


I DON'T NEED ARMOR. JUST SOME STONES FOR MY SLING.


WITH ONLY HIS SHEPHERD'S STAFF AND A SLING, DAVID GOES OUT TO MEET THE PHILISTINE GIANT. THE ARMIES OF BOTH CAMPS WATCH THEIR CHAMPIONS AS THEY FACE EACH OTHER.
HA! HA! HA!
DO YOU THINK I'M A DOG, THAT YOU CAN CHASE ME AWAY WITH STICKS AND STONES?
I'LL GIVE YOUR FLESH TO THE WILD ANIMALS.
YOU COME WITH A SWORD, A SPEAR, AND A SHIELD. BUT I COME IN THE NAME OF GOD, WHO WILL GIVE ME THE VICTORY.
WHISH
THE GIANT LAUGHS—BUT DAVID WHIRLS HIS SLING, TAKES CAREFUL AIM, AND LETS THE STONE FLY ...


DAVID HAS SLAIN GOLIATH WITH A SINGLE SHOT FROM HIS SLING. HE RUNS TO THE BODY, GRABS GOLIATH'S SWORD, AND HOLDS IT UP IN VICTORY.
KRAK
UNGH...
LET EVERYONE KNOW THAT OUR GOD DOES NOT NEED HUMAN WEAPONS! THIS BATTLE IS THE LORD'S, AND HE HAS DELIVERED THE PHILISTINES TO US!
IT MUST HAVE BEEN A GOD! HOW ELSE COULD A MERE BOY DEFEAT GOLIATH?
IN TERROR, THE PHILISTINES FLEE FOR THEIR LIVES. SPURRED ON BY THIS SUDDEN TURN OF EVENTS, THE EXCITED ISRAELITES CHASE THE PHILISTINES BACK TO THEIR OWN LAND.

The Jealous King

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 18–19



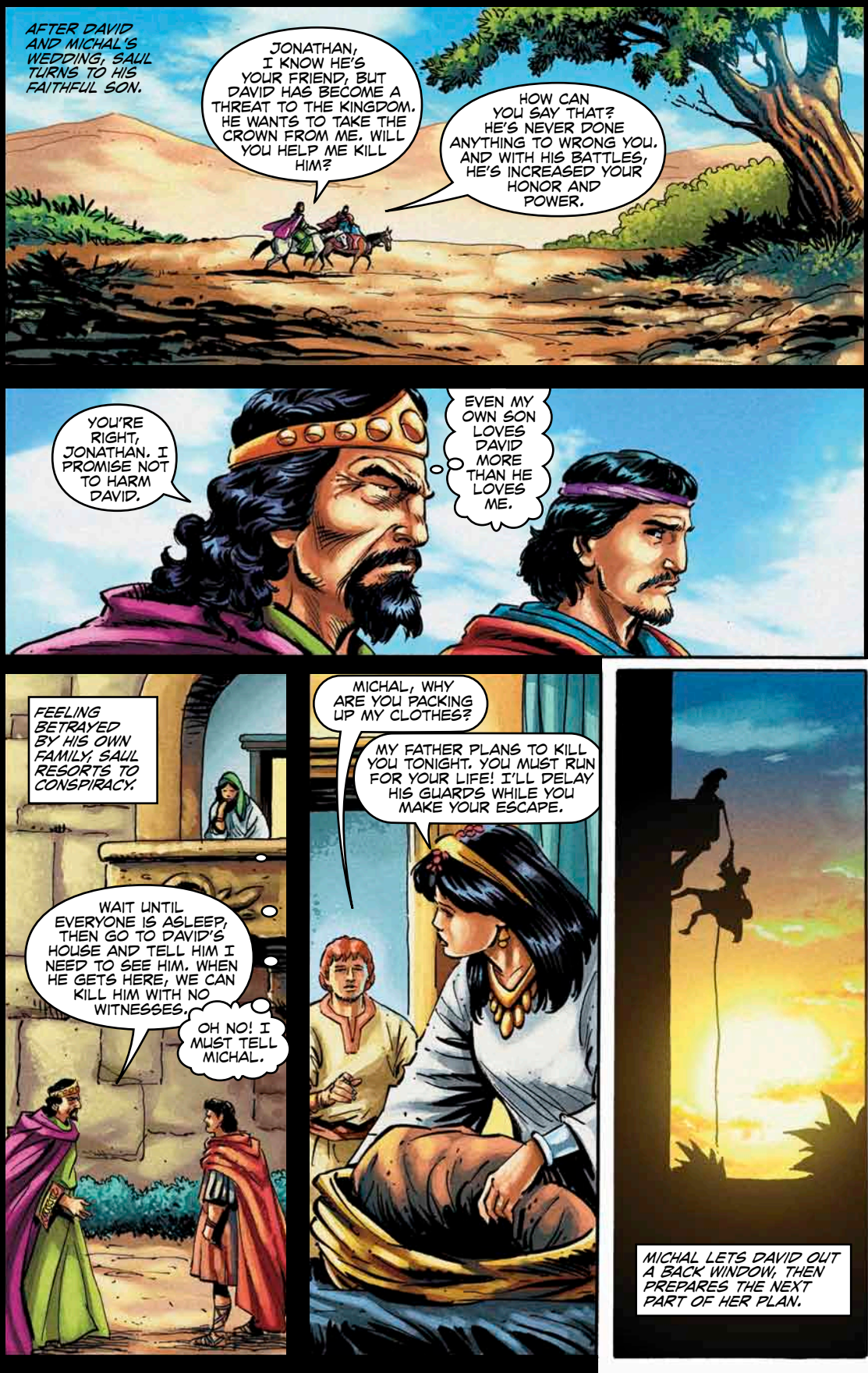







THE PEOPLE'S PRAISE OF DAVID TURNS SAUL'S APPRECIATION TO RAGE. HE THINKS OF WHAT THE PROPHET SAMUEL TOLD HIM. "THE LORD WILL TAKE YOUR KINGDOM FROM YOU."
THE PEOPLE KNOW DAVID IS A GREATER WARRIOR THAN I AM. MAYBE HE'S THE ONE WHO WILL TAKE MY KINGDOM FROM ME!
THAT NIGHT, SAUL CANNOT SLEEP.
MY SOLDIERS ALREADY LOVE HIM, AND NOW MY PEOPLE LOVE HIM.
ONE DAY, WHILE DAVID PLAYS THE HARP TO SOOTHE SAUL'S SPIRIT ...
DAVID! HE'S THE HERO NOW! BUT HE CAN'T TAKE MY KINGDOM FROM ME IF HE'S DEAD.
IN A BURST OF RAGE, SAUL GRABS A SPEAR.
THUNK
I MISSED!
I'M SORRY, DAVID. I DON'T KNOW WHAT CAME OVER ME. IT MUST BE THIS EVIL SPIRIT THAT TORMENTS ME.
IT MUST HAVE BEEN AN ACCIDENT. WHY WOULD HE HAVE PROMOTED ME ONLY TO KILL ME?
BUT SAUL'S JEALOUSY CONTINUES TO GROW BECAUSE HE KNOWS DAVID HAS THE LORD'S FAVOR.

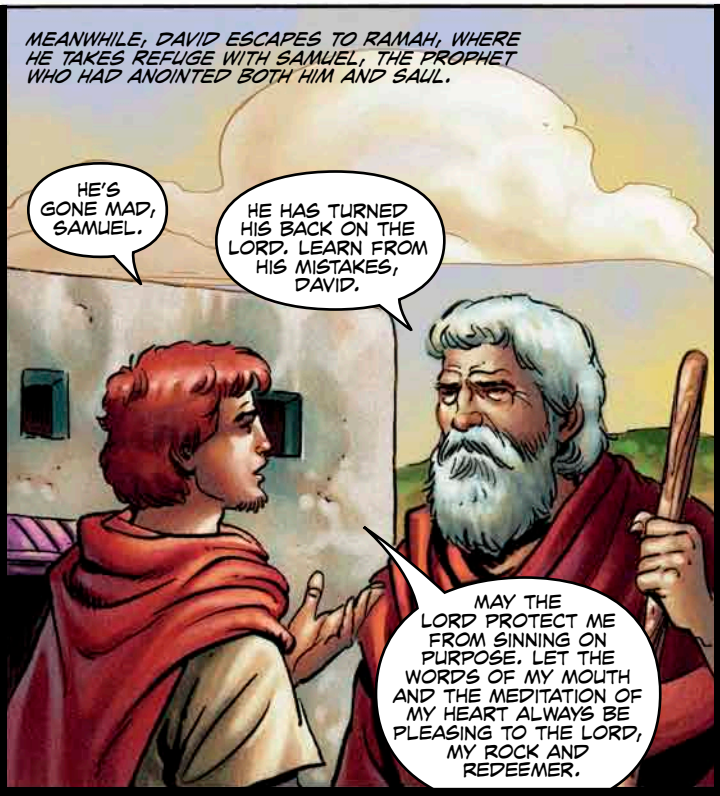

NOT ONLY DOES THE LORD FAVOR DAVID, SO DOES SAUL'S DAUGHTER, MICHAL.
THAT GIVES ME AN IDEA.
DAVID, IT SEEMS MY DAUGHTER IS IN LOVE WITH YOU. AND WHO CAN BLAME HER? YOU ARE THE MOST POPULAR MAN IN THE KINGDOM. BUT SINCE YOU ARE A POOR COMMONER, YOU CANNOT AFFORD THE CUSTOMARY BRIDE PRICE FOR A KING'S DAUGHTER. SO I WILL WAIVE THAT FEE. HOWEVER, TO PROVE YOUR VALOR, YOU MUST KILL 100 PHILISTINES.
THANK YOU, MY KING. I AM HIGHLY HONORED.
YOU MAY BE ABLE TO BEAT ONE GIANT PHILISTINE, BUT 100 OF THEM SHOULD BE ABLE TO KILL YOU.
ONE MONTH LATER ...
WELL? DID YOU KILL 100 PHILISTINES?
NO.
I KILLED 200.


AFTER DAVID AND MICHAL'S WEDDING, SAUL TURNS TO HIS FAITHFUL SON.
JONATHAN, I KNOW HE'S YOUR FRIEND, BUT DAVID HAS BECOME A THREAT TO THE KINGDOM. HE WANTS TO TAKE THE CROWN FROM ME. WILL YOU HELP ME KILL HIM?
HOW CAN YOU SAY THAT? HE'S NEVER DONE ANYTHING TO WRONG YOU. AND WITH HIS BATTLES, HE'S INCREASED YOUR HONOR AND POWER.
YOU'RE RIGHT, JONATHAN. I PROMISE NOT TO HARM DAVID.
EVEN MY OWN SON LOVES DAVID MORE THAN HE LOVES ME.
FEELING BETRAYED BY HIS OWN FAMILY, SAUL RESORTS TO CONSPIRACY.
WAIT UNTIL EVERYONE IS ASLEEP, THEN GO TO DAVID'S HOUSE AND TELL HIM I NEED TO SEE HIM. WHEN HE GETS HERE, WE CAN KILL HIM WITH NO WITNESSES.
OH NO! I MUST TELL MICHAL.
MICHAL, WHY ARE YOU PACKING UP MY CLOTHES?
MY FATHER PLANS TO KILL YOU TONIGHT. YOU MUST RUN FOR YOUR LIFE! I'LL DELAY HIS GUARDS WHILE YOU MAKE YOUR ESCAPE.
MICHAL LETS DAVID OUT A BACK WINDOW, THEN PREPARES THE NEXT PART OF HER PLAN.


LET US IN! KING SAUL NEEDS TO SEE DAVID ON A MATTER OF HIGH IMPORTANCE!
AS YOU CAN SEE, HE'S SICK IN BED. I THINK IT'S CONTAGIOUS. I'D LET YOU IN, BUT THEN YOU'D BE CEREMONIALLY UNCLEAN FOR BEING NEAR A SICK PERSON. I'M SO SORRY.
MICHAL'S BOLD LIE CONFUSES THE GUARDS, WHO BRING THIS NEW DEVELOPMENT TO SAUL. AT FIRST, HE SEEMS TO TAKE THE NEWS CALMLY.
OH, I DIDN'T REALIZE HE WAS SICK. WE'LL WAIT UNTIL HE'S HEALTHY BEFORE WE KILL HIM.
YOU FOOLS!
BRING HIM HERE NOW IF YOU HAVE TO CARRY HIM IN HIS BED TO DO IT!
BUT WHEN THE MEN BARGE INTO DAVID'S ROOM, THEY FIND ONLY A STATUE WITH A GOAT HAIR WIG IN HIS BED.
HOW COULD MY OWN DAUGHTER LIE TO ME TO PROTECT MY ENEMY?
HE'S NOT YOUR ENEMY, FATHER!
I WILL THINK OF A SUITABLE PUNISHMENT FOR YOU.

A Prince of a Friend

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 19:18—20:42; PSALM 19

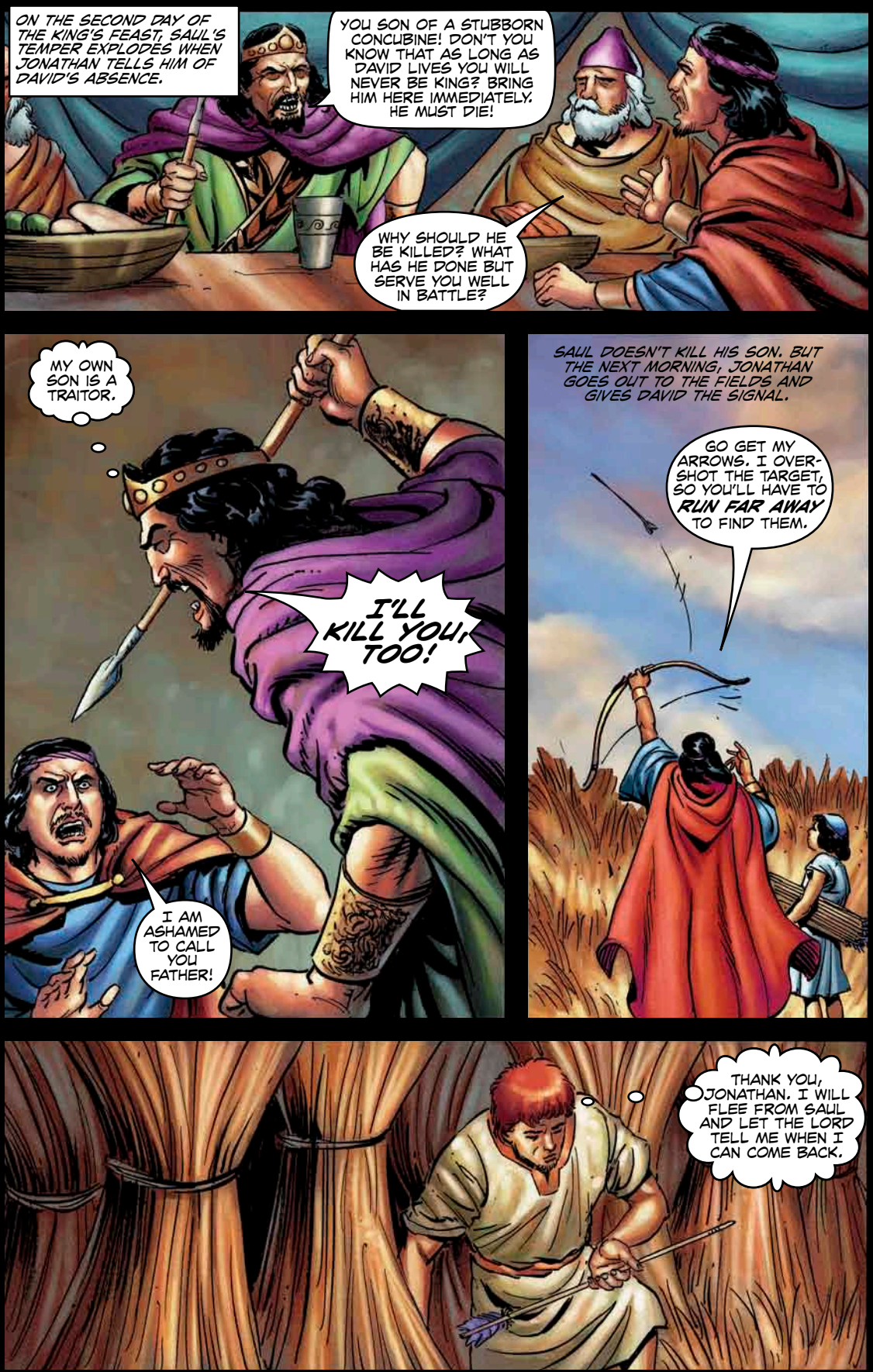






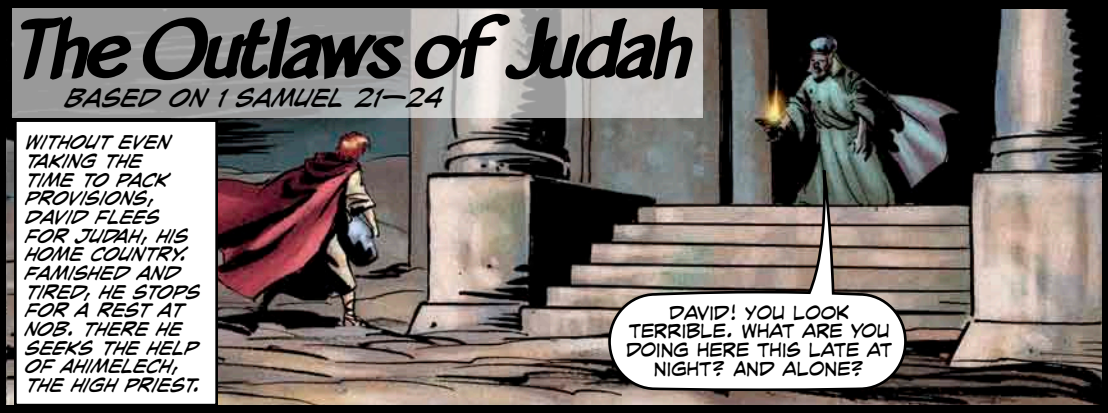


TOGETHER, THE TWO HATCH A PLAN. DAVID WILL HIDE IN THE FIELD DURING THE ROYAL FESTIVAL DINNER. IF KING SAUL DOESN'T MIND THAT DAVID IS ABSENT, IT'S BECAUSE HE'S NOT WORRIED ABOUT DAVID. BUT IF HE BECOMES ANGRY, JONATHAN WILL KNOW THAT IT'S BECAUSE HE STILL SEEKS DAVID'S DEATH. THEN HE WILL GO BACK TO THE FIELD AND USE A CODE TO LET DAVID KNOW THE ANSWER.


ON THE SECOND DAY OF THE KING'S FEAST, SAUL'S TEMPER EXPLODES WHEN JONATHAN TELLS HIM OF DAVID'S ABSENCE.
YOU SON OF A STUBBORN CONCUBINE! DON'T YOU KNOW THAT AS LONG AS DAVID LIVES YOU WILL NEVER BE KING? BRING HIM HERE IMMEDIATELY. HE MUST DIE!
WHY SHOULD HE BE KILLED? WHAT HAS HE DONE BUT SERVE YOU WELL IN BATTLE?
MY OWN SON IS A TRAITOR.
I'LL KILL YOU, TOO!
I AM ASHAMED TO CALL YOU FATHER!
SAUL DOESN'T KILL HIS SON. BUT THE NEXT MORNING, JONATHAN GOES OUT TO THE FIELDS AND GIVES DAVID THE SIGNAL.
GO GET MY ARROWS. I OVERSHOT THE TARGET, SO YOU'LL HAVE TO RUN FAR AWAY TO FIND THEM.
THANK YOU, JONATHAN. I WILL FLEE FROM SAUL AND LET THE LORD TELL ME WHEN I CAN COME BACK.

The Outlaws of Judah

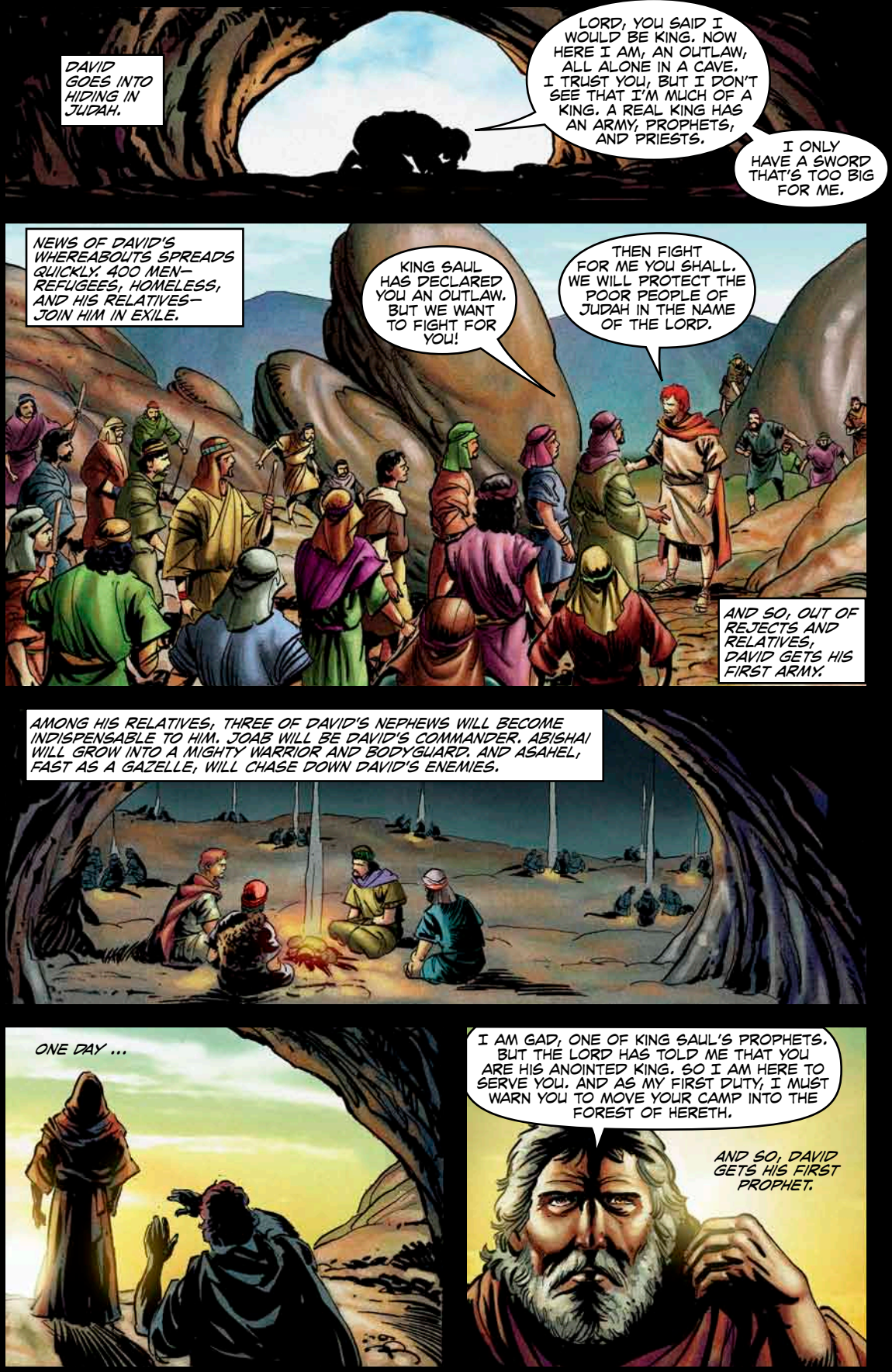
BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 21–24

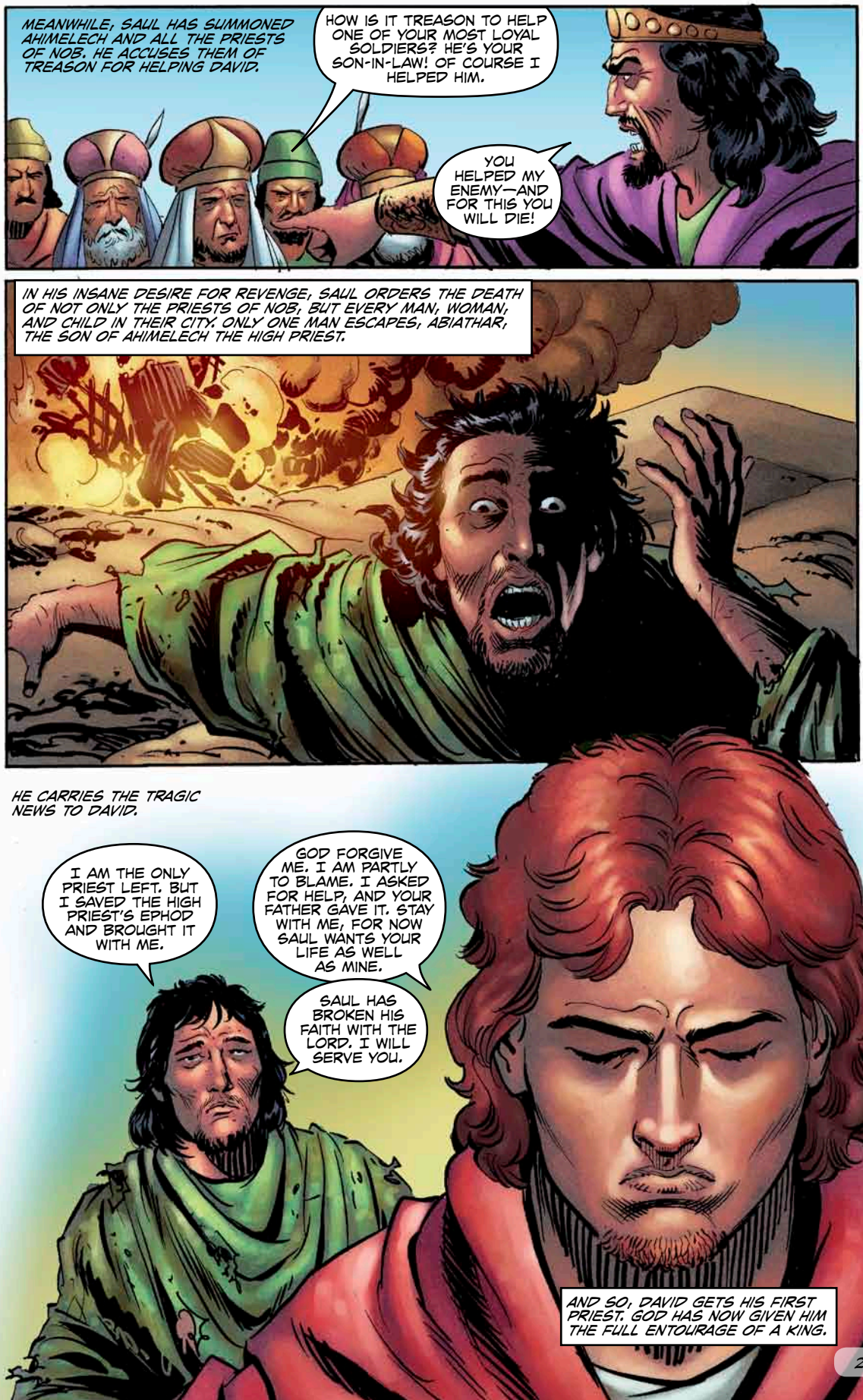






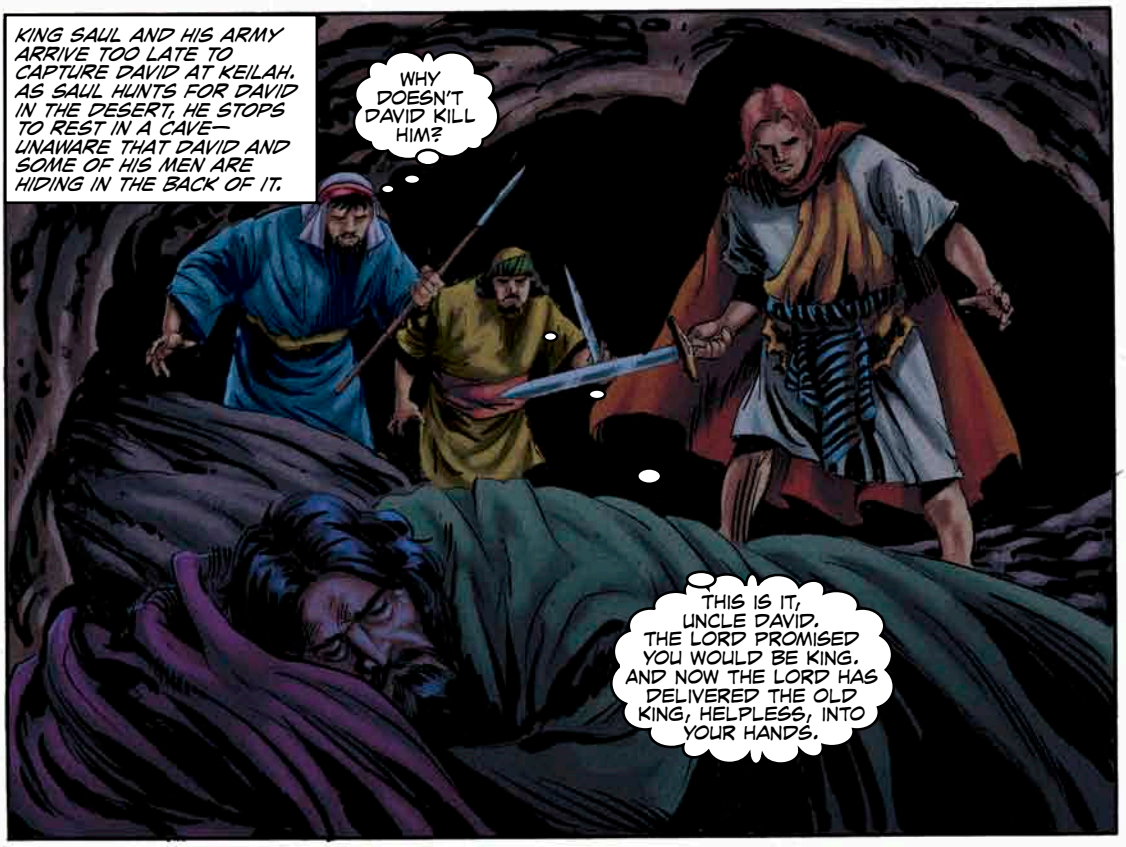


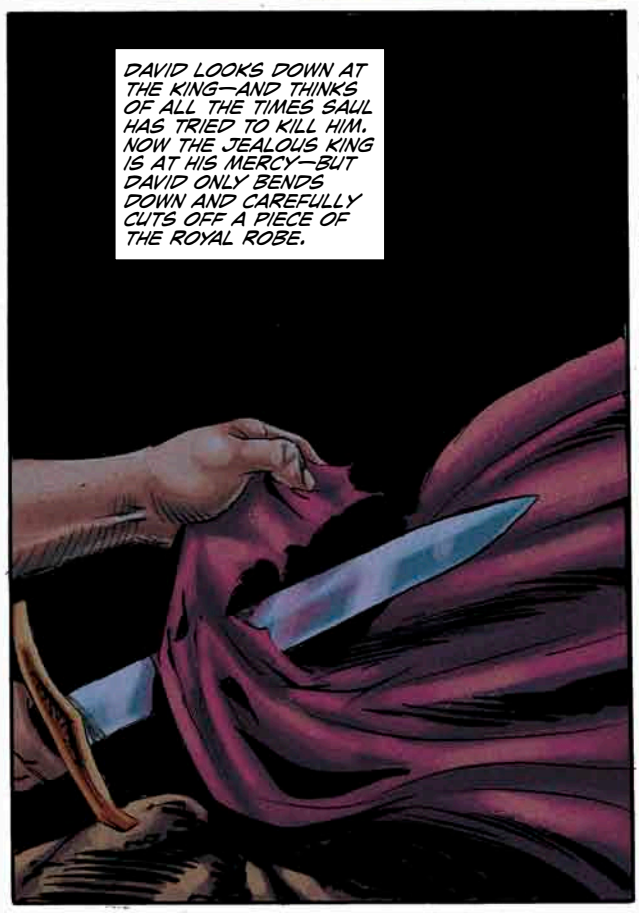

DAVID GOES INTO HIDING IN JUDAH.
LORD, YOU SAID I WOULD BE KING. NOW HERE I AM, AN OUTLAW, ALL ALONE IN A CAVE. I TRUST YOU, BUT I DON'T SEE THAT I'M MUCH OF A KING. A REAL KING HAS AN ARMY, PROPHETS, AND PRIESTS.
I ONLY HAVE A SWORD THAT'S TOO BIG FOR ME.
NEWS OF DAVID'S WHEREABOUTS SPREADS QUICKLY. 400 MEN—REFUGEES, HOMELESS, AND HIS RELATIVES—JOIN HIM IN EXILE.
KING SAUL HAS DECLARED YOU AN OUTLAW. BUT WE WANT TO FIGHT FOR YOU!
THEN FIGHT FOR ME YOU SHALL. WE WILL PROTECT THE POOR PEOPLE OF JUDAH IN THE NAME OF THE LORD.
AND SO, OUT OF REJECTS AND RELATIVES, DAVID GETS HIS FIRST ARMY.
AMONG HIS RELATIVES, THREE OF DAVID'S NEPHEWS WILL BECOME INDISPENSABLE TO HIM. JOAB WILL BE DAVID'S COMMANDER. ABISHAI WILL GROW INTO A MIGHTY WARRIOR AND BODYGUARD. AND ASAHEL, FAST AS A GAZELLE, WILL CHASE DOWN DAVID'S ENEMIES.
ONE DAY ...
I AM GAD, ONE OF KING SAUL'S PROPHETS. BUT THE LORD HAS TOLD ME THAT YOU ARE HIS ANOINTED KING. SO I AM HERE TO SERVE YOU. AND AS MY FIRST DUTY, I MUST WARN YOU TO MOVE YOUR CAMP INTO THE FOREST OF HERETH.
AND SO, DAVID GETS HIS FIRST PROPHET.


MEANWHILE, SAUL HAS SUMMONED AHIMELECH AND ALL THE PRIESTS OF NOB. HE ACCUSES THEM OF TREASON FOR HELPING DAVID.
HOW IS IT TREASON TO HELP ONE OF YOUR MOST LOYAL SOLDIERS? HE'S YOUR SON-IN-LAW! OF COURSE I HELPED HIM.
YOU HELPED MY ENEMY—AND FOR THIS YOU WILL DIE!
IN HIS INSANE DESIRE FOR REVENGE, SAUL ORDERS THE DEATH OF NOT ONLY THE PRIESTS OF NOB, BUT EVERY MAN, WOMAN, AND CHILD IN THEIR CITY. ONLY ONE MAN ESCAPES, ABIATHAR, THE SON OF AHIMELECH THE HIGH PRIEST.
HE CARRIES THE TRAGIC NEWS TO DAVID.
I AM THE ONLY PRIEST LEFT. BUT I SAVED THE HIGH PRIEST'S EPHOD AND BROUGHT IT WITH ME.
GOD FORGIVE ME. I AM PARTLY TO BLAME. I ASKED FOR HELP, AND YOUR FATHER GAVE IT. STAY WITH ME, FOR NOW SAUL WANTS YOUR LIFE AS WELL AS MINE.
SAUL HAS BROKEN HIS FAITH WITH THE LORD. I WILL SERVE YOU.
AND SO, DAVID GETS HIS FIRST PRIEST. GOD HAS NOW GIVEN HIM THE FULL ENTOURAGE OF A KING.


GAD INFORMS DAVID THAT PHILISTINES HAVE ATTACKED THE POOR TOWN OF KEILAH. AND ABIATHAR RELAYS GOD'S COMMAND TO ATTACK AND RESCUE HIS FELLOW JUDEANS. DAVID'S MEN, HOWEVER, ARE LESS THAN CONFIDENT.
WE HAVE NO TRAINING!
WE CAN'T FIGHT AGAINST A PHILISTINE ARMY.
ACTUALLY, I'M IN THE MIDDLE OF A FAST.
IT'S TRUE, UNCLE. IT'S ONE THING TO DEFEND YOU AGAINST SAUL, BUT THE PHILISTINES ARE TOO STRONG FOR US.
MEN OF JUDAH! OUR FATHER PROPHESIED, "YOUR HAND SHALL WRING YOUR ENEMIES' NECKS. NOW YOU CROUCH IN HIDING, LIKE A YOUNG LION. BUT WHO WILL DARE PROVOKE YOU?" LIONS OF JUDAH! GOD HAS DELIVERED OUR ENEMY INTO OUR HANDS! FIGHT WITH ME! FIGHT FOR YOUR FAMILIES! FIGHT FOR GOD!


ENCOURAGED BY DAVID'S WORDS, HIS MEN SHAKE OFF THEIR FEAR AND MARCH TO FIGHT. THEY INFLICT HEAVY LOSSES ON THE PHILISTINES, TAKING THEIR PLUNDER AND SHARING IT WITH THE PEOPLE OF KEILAH.
BUT WHILE THEY ARE CELEBRATING THEIR FIRST VICTORY, DAVID'S PROPHET AND PRIEST BRING HIM TROUBLING NEWS.
DAVID, GOD WARNED ME THAT SAUL IS ON HIS WAY HERE TO CAPTURE YOU.
ABIATHAR, USE THE EPHOD TO ASK THE LORD IF THE PEOPLE OF KEILAH WILL DEFEND ME OR HAND ME OVER TO SAUL.
THE LORD SAYS THEY WILL BETRAY YOU TO SAUL.
THEN LET'S GO.
EVEN THOUGH HE HAS JUST RESCUED THEIR TOWN, DAVID IS FORCED TO FLEE FROM THE FICKLE CITIZENS OF KEILAH AND HIDE IN NEARBY CAVES. HOWEVER, 200 MEN ARE IMPRESSED BY HIS BRAVERY AND JOIN HIS ARMY. HE NOW HAS 600 SOLDIERS.


KING SAUL AND HIS ARMY ARRIVE TOO LATE TO CAPTURE DAVID AT KEILAH. AS SAUL HUNTS FOR DAVID IN THE DESERT, HE STOPS TO REST IN A CAVE—UNAWARE THAT DAVID AND SOME OF HIS MEN ARE HIDING IN THE BACK OF IT.
WHY DOESN'T DAVID KILL HIM?
THIS IS IT, UNCLE DAVID. THE LORD PROMISED YOU WOULD BE KING. AND NOW THE LORD HAS DELIVERED THE OLD KING, HELPLESS, INTO YOUR HANDS.

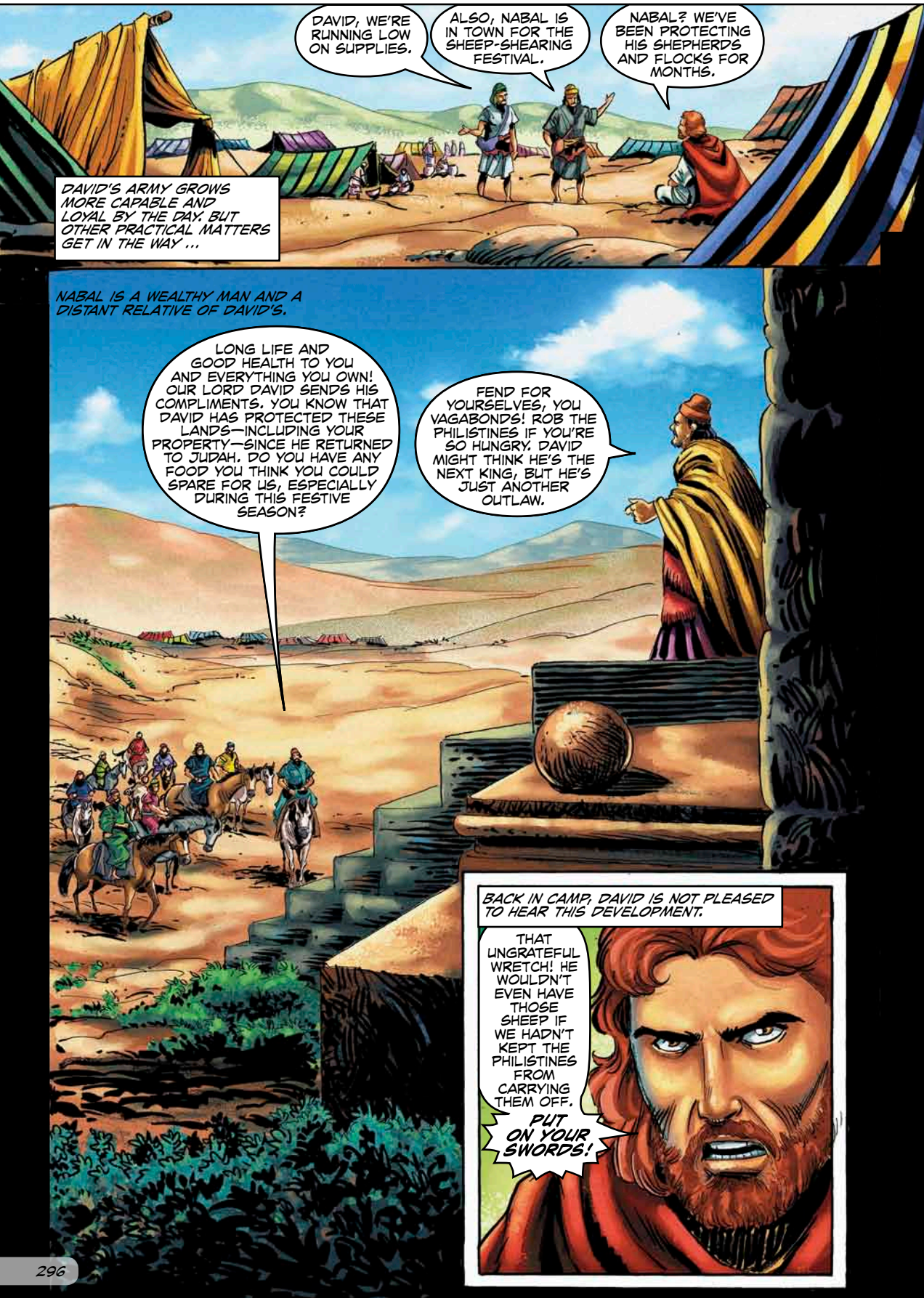

DAVID LOOKS DOWN AT THE KING—AND THINKS OF ALL THE TIMES SAUL HAS TRIED TO KILL HIM. NOW THE JEALOUS KING IS AT HIS MERCY—BUT DAVID ONLY BENDS DOWN AND CAREFULLY CUTS OFF A PIECE OF THE ROYAL ROBE.


I UNDERSTAND. HE'S YOUR FATHER-IN-LAW. IF YOU DON'T WANT TO KILL HIM, I'LL DO IT FOR YOU.
NO! HE WAS CHOSEN BY GOD TO BE OUR KING. IT'S NOT FOR US TO DECIDE WHEN HE WILL DIE.


AFTER A WHILE, SAUL LEAVES THE CAVE—AND DAVID CALLS AFTER HIM.
MY LORD, THE KING!
DAVID!
WHY DO YOU KEEP HUNTING ME? I MEAN YOU NO HARM. SEE THIS PIECE OF CLOTH? I CUT IT FROM YOUR ROBE. I COULD HAVE KILLED YOU, BUT I DIDN'T.
MY FATHER, IF I HAVE WRONGED GOD, LET HIM JUDGE ME. BUT HOW HAVE I WRONGED YOU?
I AM ASHAMED. YOU ARE A BETTER MAN THAN I AM, DAVID. I WILL GO AND LEAVE YOU ALONE.
SAUL LEADS HIS ARMY AWAY. BUT A SHORT TIME LATER DAVID LEARNS THAT SAUL HAS FORCED MICHAL, DAVID'S WIFE, TO MARRY ANOTHER MAN. THIS SHOWS DAVID THAT SAUL HAS NOT FORGIVEN HIM. WORD COMES, TOO, THAT AFTER MANY YEARS OF SERVING THE LORD, THE PROPHET SAMUEL HAS DIED.

A Fool and His Wife ...

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 25




TWO SERVANTS RUN TO TELL NABAL'S WIFE, ABIGAIL, WHAT HAPPENED.
DAVID'S MEN CAME ASKING FOR FOOD, AND OUR MASTER SENT THEM AWAY WITH NOTHING BUT INSULTS. DAVID'S MEN REALLY WERE VERY GOOD TO US. BUT OUR FOOLISH LORD WON'T LISTEN TO US AND ... AND ... WE'RE AFRAID OF HOW DAVID WILL RESPOND.
QUICKLY! FOLLOW ME.
200 LOAVES OF BREAD ... 2 SKINS OF WINE ... 5 SHEEP ... 5 BUSHELS OF GRAIN ... 100 RAISIN CAKES ... IS THAT ENOUGH? HMM, ADD 200 FIG CAKES.
ANYTHING ELSE?
YES. DON'T MENTION THIS TO MY HUSBAND. I'M OFF TO PROTECT HIS FOOLISH LIFE.
MEANWHILE ...
... NOT TO MENTION THE WASTE OF EFFORT, PROTECTING THAT FOOL'S FORTUNE. HE HAS PAID ME BACK EVIL FOR GOOD. WITH GOD AS MY WITNESS, NO ONE IN HIS HOUSE WILL BE ALIVE TOMORROW!


DAVID AND HIS ARMY SET OUT JUST AS ABIGAIL ARRIVES WITH HER PROVISIONS. WHEN ABIGAIL SEES DAVID SUDDENLY APPEAR WITH FURY IN HIS EYES, SHE FALLS TO HER KNEES.
MY LORD AND FUTURE KING!
LISTEN TO ME, PLEASE! IGNORE THE INSULTS OF MY STUPID HUSBAND, NABAL. HIS NAME MEANS "FOOL" FOR A REASON. PLEASE, MY MASTER, DON'T SINK TO HIS LEVEL. DON'T BLOODY YOUR HANDS FOR THE SAKE OF REVENGE. LET THE LORD JUDGE NABAL FOR HIS WICKEDNESS. WHEN YOU ARE KING, YOU WILL NOT WANT YOUR PEOPLE TO SAY YOU MURDERED ONE OF YOUR OWN SUBJECTS.
DAVID'S ANGER HAS COOLED DURING THIS FAITHFUL WOMAN'S BRAVE SPEECH.
PRAISE THE LORD FOR SENDING YOU! YOU HAVE SAVED BOTH MY HONOR AND INNOCENT LIVES. THANK YOU FOR THIS GIFT. TAKE YOUR DONKEYS AND GO IN PEACE.


THE NEXT MORNING, WHEN ABIGAIL TELLS NABAL ABOUT HIS NARROW ESCAPE, HE IS STRUCK DEAD WITH FRIGHT.
WHEN DAVID HEARS THE NEWS, HE REALIZES HOW RIGHT ABIGAIL HAD BEEN; THE LORD PUNISHED NABAL SO THAT HE WOULD NOT HAVE TO FIGHT A FELLOW ISRAELITE.
YOU KNOW, NOW THAT SAUL HAS GIVEN MICHAL TO ANOTHER MAN IN MARRIAGE, YOU COULD USE AN INTELLIGENT AND RESOURCEFUL WOMAN AROUND HERE.
YOU'RE RIGHT! ABIGAIL HAS PROVEN HER WISDOM. AND SHE BELIEVES IN ME. I WANT TO BE THE HONORABLE, GOD-FEARING KING SHE THINKS I CAN BE. I WILL ASK HER TO BE MY WIFE.
AS DAVID'S NEW WIFE, ABIGAIL CONTINUES TO PROVE HER WISDOM AND RESOURCEFULNESS IN HELPING DAVID RUN HIS CAMP. UNDER HER INFLUENCE, HIS MEN BEGIN TO ACT LESS LIKE A BAND OF RENEGADES AND MORE LIKE A KING'S ARMY.
DAVID LEADS HIS MEN WISELY AND WELL FOR SEVERAL YEARS. BUT HE IS ALWAYS UNDER THE SHADOW OF SAUL'S JEALOUSY ...

The Fall of Saul

BASED ON 1 SAMUEL 26; 28; 31

